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Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32642056.

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Mature

**Archive Warning:**
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, F/M

**Fandom:**
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia (She-Ra), Light Hope/Mara (She-Ra)

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Antarctica, Exes, Romance, Slow Burn, Alternate Universe - Historical, 1910s, Fluff and Angst, Fluff, Angst, Adventure, Race to the South Pole, Happy Ending, Childhood Friends, Penguins, i love antarctica so much, Cooking, LGBTQ Themes, Adora is in the Royal Navy but the British are extremely horrible, themes of death, Scorpia has a crush on Catra, jealous adora, Exes to Lovers, Loosely inspired by the Amundsen-Scott race, Abandoned Work - Unfinished and Discontinued

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# Aurora Australis

by thepudz

Summary

A promise was made between Adora and Catra when they were younger: to be the first to reach the South Pole together. But throughout the years, that promise tore them apart, and they were only left with bitter memories of a relationship turned sour.

Eight years after their break-up, the year is 1910, and the two of them command their own separate ships and crew. Unintentionally, they both begin to head for Antarctica at the same time in what soon becomes known in the global newspapers as the 'Race to the South Pole', a land that has yet to be claimed by any explorer.

The world sees them as rivals trying to secure their place in the history books. The two of them see a chance to try to bury the hatchet by creating new memories of beauty and adventure—only hoping that this time, they'll last for good and not be lost to the ice.

*ABANDONED FIC*

Notes

I should probably preface this whole fic by saying that Antarctica is my FAVOURITE place in the entire world. I am absolutely self-indulging in this fic, and I can only hope y'all will enjoy the ride as much as I do.

Welcome back to another fic! I have to give a big, big thanks to Cheesybiscuit for giving me the premise of this fic. You probably know them as the author of 'you could be the death of me', the amazing Cold War AU! If you haven't read that fic

yet, I genuinely implore you to do so. It's such wonderful writing with so much thought and depth behind it.

I should also say that I'm not all that experienced with historical writing and I also have never been a captain of a ship in the 1910s, so if I write any glaring inaccuracies with the ship dialogue or general historical facts, I'm really more than happy to have friendly corrections in the comments! I do try my best with my fics, but I'm definitely challenging myself with this fic, and I'm always up for learning opportunities.

(Should probably also specify, although this fic is based off the Amundsen-Scott expeditions, it’s not completely the same. I may like angst but I am definitely not going to be THAT grim.)

Without further ado, let's jump into this story! I'm super excited to show it off, and I really hope you enjoy! As usual, I love responding to comments, and I'd love to see your thoughts <3

See the end of the work for more notes

# Promise Part 1

*January 19, 1895.*

It was early morning; the sun had yet to rise, when the young Adora heard a *clink* against her bedroom window.

A cold, sudden tap against the glass that did not echo, nor did it shatter anything.

*Clink.*

It was but an annoyance that yanked her from a deep slumber and prevented her from sinking back into it.

*Clink.*

Another one.

It wasn't frequent enough to just be a bird pecking at its own reflection, nor was there any chance someone had climbed up onto the second storey of her family home to knock on her window.

She thought it would go away eventually, but it kept coming.

*Clink*.

Each clink was drawing her further from sleep. She tried turning around in her bed to face away from the window, hoping it would deafen the sound.

*Clink.*

She sighed, bunching up the pillow beneath her head to cover her ears. It had to be an ungodly hour. Her eyes felt heavy, and her body felt sluggish.

*Clink*.

The sound wasn't going away.

Adora groaned, pressing her hands against her face and squeezing tight to wake herself up, before pulling the sheets off her body and swinging her legs over the side of the bed, placing them against the cold floor.

With the warmth of the sheets gone, a shiver sliced up through Adora's body. She only wore a white, silky nightgown, which did her no favours against the cold England winter.

Going over to the source of the noise, she quickly drew the curtain from her window and pushed the glass frame open. She peeked her head out and looked around for any annoying birds.

None in sight.

There weren't even any rodents, nor was there any rain. So instead, she looked down to see…

"Catra?!"

Adora spoke her name louder than intended.

The twelve-year-old Catra stood outside on the ground floor, looking up at Adora's bedroom with a smile on her face. She held a dozen pebbles in her left hand and gripped an oil lamp in her right, the dull flame emanating on her face.

Adora could see Catra was wearing a large loose shirt and pants with legs that covered her feet; an outfit clearly thrown together at the last second.

"Finally, you're awake! I've been throwing these for the last five minutes!" Catra loudly whispered up at Adora, holding up the pebbles. "Get down here!"

"Get down… What? What time is it? What in the hell are you doing?!" Adora whispered back.

"Just get down before your parents wake up!" Catra hissed, waving a hand down.

Adora almost wanted to tell her no, but she knew Catra was persistent. Rejecting her offer meant she'd have to deal with more of those dreaded *clinks* until the cows came home.

She sighed, shutting the window and drawing the curtain closed. She grabbed her mittens from the bedside table and slipped them over her cold hands, before slowly opening her bedroom door as to not create a single creak that could alert her parents.

Adora quickly and quietly made her way down the wooden stairs of her home, using her memory of the house and her limited vision to reach the front door before anyone could hear her.

Upon opening the front door, Adora was hit with a blast of cold air against her face, and she immediately wanted to go back to bed and snuggle up beneath the warm sheets.

"This had better be worth it…" Adora whispered to herself, her voice shivering.

She made her way around to the back of her comfortable home, feeling the wet cobblestone sidewalk underneath her bare feet, mixed with some specks of mud from the roads that squished between her toes.

Her feet would be filthy, mostly her own fault for neglecting to bring any footwear.

Adora spotted Catra's dull lamp and approached, her voice still a whisper. "You are an absolute fiend, you know that, Catra?"

"Of course. But you'll love this, I promise," Catra smiled.

"I'll love being woken up at… whatever hour this is on my thirteenth birthday? Really?" Adora scoffed.

"Absolutely! Now follow me. We don't have much time."

With only those few words, Catra began to jog away from the home, and Adora followed behind, though not with much enthusiasm.

Catra ventured forth towards the east, going around the backs of homes and avoiding the streets that were lit by lamps and patrolled by police or sleepless neighbours.

"Where are we going?" Adora asked as she followed behind Catra.

"You'll see. Just trust me," Catra replied. "And keep up."

"I'm *trying*," Adora insisted. "I didn't exactly bring any shoes since you didn't tell me we would be taking a stroll through the neighbourhood."

"I didn't ask for excuses, princess," Catra replied, and Adora could only scoff.

She loved Catra, but there were points where she *really* had to remind herself why.

Catra ventured around a few more houses, Adora at her tail. Her feet had gone numb by this point, but she chose to ignore it.

Soon enough, the two young girls reached a small store building with a ladder beside it. Catra began to approach the ladder, putting the metal handle of the lamp between her teeth as she grabbed onto it.

"You cannot be serious…" Adora sighed, and yet, she went along with it. Adora was *going* to see what Catra wanted her to see, no matter the time or inconvenience.

Seeing Catra's excitement was almost worth the annoyance.

Adora climbed up the ladder behind Catra, feeling the cold railings against her already frozen feet. She found it hard to grip with the mittens, and soon she had to hook her arm around the side of the ladder and pull her mittens off with her teeth.

With both her feet frozen and her hands soon to meet the same fate, Adora was *really* hoping Catra wasn't just leading her around for nothing.

She reached the rooftop of the store to see Catra put out the flame in the lamp, reaching down to grab Adora's hand and pulling her up.

"Quickly, we're about to miss it," Catra hurriedly spoke.

"I'm coming, I'm coming," Adora huffed, getting to her feet.

The two of them ran across the roof of the building, taking a short and steady leap to the neighbouring one. The buildings being packed so close and being the same height made for an easy journey.

After a few more buildings, they reached one that was only a couple of metres higher than the rest. Although there was no ladder, Adora and Catra knew the drill.

Catra put her back to the wall of the tall building, bending down slightly and cupping her hands over her bent knee. Adora put her feet to Catra's hands, using her as a boost to reach the roof of the tall building and pull herself up.

"Holy hell, your feet are disgusting," Catra whispered as she boosted Adora up, wiping her hands clean of mud afterwards.

"Oh, I *wonder* why."

Adora reached an arm over the ledge, watching Catra take a few steps back, before getting a running leap up. Adora quickly grabbed Catra by the wrist, pulling her up and onto the roof.

With both girls on the tallest roof they could get to, they took a second to catch their breath. Adora felt her own feet, not surprised to find a sensation similar to touching ice. Dunking them in hot water would be a painful experience later.

For now, Adora had other things to focus on.

She saw Catra stand up, looking to the sky for a few seconds, before she turned and extended a hand down to Adora.

"Grab my hand and close your eyes," Catra instructed.

Adora looked at her hand. "I thought you wanted me to *see* something."

"I do. Now grab my hand and close your eyes. Trust me."

Adora looked up to the face of her friend and saw *that* smile on Catra's face. That warm smile that curled up into her slightly puffy cheeks, her brows raised lovingly, and her eyes soft and tender.

It was the same smile Adora saw after she saved Catra from a group of bullies when they were five (though it was a tad dramatic, since Catra was handling herself just fine, but she appreciated someone looking out for her).

The same smile during their first night together after telling each other stories and making each other laugh for hours when they were seven.

The same smile when they were ten and they promised each other they would sail the world together and go to places where no one had ever been.

That smile always meant good things.

So of course Adora trusted her. She'd always trust Catra.

And so, she took her hand, stood up, and closed her eyes.

She soon heard Catra walk around behind her and felt Catra's hands cover her eyes. "No peeking."

"I'm not," Adora chuckled. "Your hands are freezing!"

Catra took a breath as she slowly began to step forward, guiding her friend across the rooftop, and she soon asked one single question.

“Adora… Have you ever heard of Aurora Australis?”

Certainly not a question Adora had expected.

“I haven’t.”

Catra took a few more steps, before bringing the two of them to a stop. She took a gentle breath, and Adora felt Catra’s sigh against the back of her neck.

“It’s one of the most amazing events in the entire world,” Catra spoke. “Like someone painted the stars with the brightest colours they could find. It’s a whole series of bright lights that fill the night sky. Green, red, blue…”

“Whoa…”

“You can only see it at the southern parts of the world, but there’s one specific place where it’s most beautiful.”

“Where’s that?”

“Antarctica.”

Adora remembered that name, faintly. The southernmost part of the world, where ice dominates and the cold fills the air even worse than an English winter.

“I read about Aurora Australis in a book from this explorer. Her name is Mara Hope. She got back from an expedition which was meant to be a search for whales,” Catra explained. “But when she saw the Aurora Australis… She called it the second most beautiful sight of her entire life.”

“The second? What’s the first?”

“She never specified. But I couldn’t get the description out of my head. I want you to picture this, Adora,” Catra instructed.

“Okay…” Adora nodded.

Catra took a breath. “It was night. The sun never rises in Antarctica during the winter months, so it had been night for a long, long time. The boat was just about to head back home, and Mara was ready to finish her reports. She decided to look around at the ocean of Antarctica one last time… Until suddenly, it began to glow.”

As Catra spoke, Adora began to picture all this in her head. Her imagination placed her in the shoes of Mara Hope, an explorer, a risk-taker, a brave woman. She could picture every moment.

“At first, she thought she was hallucinating… But when she looked up, she saw that the darkness of the sky had been filled with green that shined like the leaves in Spring. It was a bright light that went on for miles…” Catra spoke with wonder in her voice.

She took her hands away from Adora’s eyes.

“At first, she couldn’t believe what she was seeing. It felt like magic. She closed her eyes, rubbing them, almost thinking it was a dream… But then she looked up to the sky, and one last time, she opened her eyes…”

And Adora did the same.

The sky around her had filled with a deep, orange glow as the sun began to rise in the distance.

Puffy white clouds were brought into the light, and the warmth filled her heart and soul as she took in the sensation of a hug from the sunrise.

The sky was not blue, but a dark orange mixed with some violet. Adora looked around with wide eyes at the beautiful sight, turning her whole body around and letting out a long, gentle gasp.

“I know a sunrise and Aurora Australis aren’t exactly the same thing, but… I was hoping you’d feel that same wonder I felt when I read Mara’s book,” Catra explained as she looked to Adora’s amazed eyes. “Because…”

“Because…?” Adora looked from the sunrise to her friend.

Catra looked to the ground for a few seconds, contemplating her next words, before curving her lips into a smile and looking to Adora. The sunrise almost sparkling in her eyes as orange filled the sky behind her.

“I was hoping you’d come with me to Antarctica so we could see Aurora Australis together.”

Adora blinked. “… Right now?”

“What? No, not right now!” Catra chuckled. “I mean… In the future. When we actually have that boat we always talked about. I want our first destination to be Antarctica. I want to go to the South Pole. And I want to see those lights with you.”

“Has… anyone ever been to the South Pole?” Adora asked.

“People have been to Antarctica, but… No one has reached the South Pole,” Catra spoke. But she soon grinned, placing a hand on Adora’s shoulder. “That’s why we’re going to be the first to get there.”

Adora took in Catra’s words. They had talked about their future dream of sailing the world many times, but it always felt like they were just talking about a fantasy.

These words were real. Catra was serious about this.

Adora placed her hand over Catra’s, holding it gently and looking into her eyes. Without a hint of hesitation, Adora nodded. “Okay.”

“Okay…?” Catra raised her eyebrows.

“We’ll do it,” Adora spoke sternly. “We’ll be the first to reach the South Pole and we’ll see Aurora Australis together.”

“You promise?” Catra asked, her grin growing wider. “I’m not joking here.”

“I’m not either,” Adora grinned right back. She gripped Catra’s hand tight and spoke the two most important words.

“I promise.”

Catra couldn’t help but slightly bounce on the balls of her feet, quickly taking her hand away to reach into her deep pockets. “Good. Because I spent a *lot* of my income on your gift and I didn’t want it to go to waste…”

“What is it?” Adora asked, trying to glance into Catra’s pocket.

Soon enough, Catra managed to pull a gift out, holding it up before Adora in the palm of her hand.

It was a ring.

Silver, shiny, with a chain linked through the loop to be used as a necklace. Adora looked at the ring with a stunned expression.

“It’s a promise ring,” Catra smiled. “As long as you have it, you have to keep your promise, okay? If you ever hand it back to me…”

“I won’t,” Adora shook her head, taking the ring in her hand. “I’ll keep my promise, no matter what.”

Catra smiled as Adora took the ring in her hand, and the excitement of Adora’s involvement and eagerness all became a whirlwind of joy in her rapidly beating heart.

In less than a second, as Adora took her gift, Catra leaned in and placed a gentle kiss on Adora’s cheek.

Adora's smile quickly faded, her jaw going slack. She looked to Catra with wide eyes, her breath escaping in a soft, drawn-out gasp.

Catra saw that expression and immediately regretted every single moment of her life.

"I…"

Catra felt the basic knowledge to even speak slip away from her brain as she realised just what she did. She wanted to run away forever.

She kissed Adora. She *kissed* Adora. Why the hell did she kiss Adora?

But just before she could curl up into a ball and die, Catra soon felt Adora do something just as crazy.

She pressed her own lips to Catra's cheek in return.

"There," Adora replied. "Promise kiss."

Catra looked to her friend, who was now smiling once more. She rubbed her own cheek where Adora had laid a kiss, and couldn't help but chuckle at how freaked out she was.

That chuckle led to Adora laughing as well. And Adora's laughter only fuelled Catra's joy, which then fuelled Adora's once more.

They soon joined together in simple laughter. Laughter that was filled with both a gentle embarrassment, but also a feeling of pure, blissful, young love.

They loved each other, Adora and Catra. And now, they had a promise to keep to each other. A promise that could never be broken.

Antarctica. Aurora Australis. The South Pole.

No matter what, they had each other.

And nothing really bad could happen as long as they had each other.

---

*October 28, 1910.*

The ocean in Madeira was bluer than any water Scorpia had ever seen.

She stood on the starboard side of the ship known as Fram, looking over the ledge and into the depths below. The ship rocked slightly with the gentle waves, but the anchor held it in place.

She smiled as she looked from the ocean up to the land before her, seeing rivers, trees, patches of grass and distant mountains. Madeira was only a quick stop for supplies, but for these last couple of hours, Scorpia had time to breathe.

For the most part.

She heard a pair of footsteps approach her from her right, and she turned to see the second mate of Fram, Entrapta, walking towards her in an almost timid manner, much unlike her usual excited demeanour.

"Nice to see you join us out here!" Scorpia beamed upon seeing her fellow crewmate.

"Hi, Scorpia… Is the captain on deck?" Entrapta asked quietly.

"Hey… Are you okay?" Scorpia asked. "You don't seem as bubbly as usual."

"Yes, well… unfortunately I just received news that… isn't great," Entrapta spoke with a slight wince.

"Well… the captain went out with Emily three-quarters of an hour ago," Scorpia explained. "What's happened?"

In response, Entrapta handed Scorpia one thing: a small report folder. Entrapta was in charge in communications and information, and she often brought only the usual daily news and updates from Norway, where Fram was stationed.

But today, the update was different.

Scorpia felt her heart drop as she read the report.

"I… I see," Scorpia spoke softly, clearing her throat. "The captain… certainly isn't going to be happy with this."

"Do you think we should signal her to return?" Entrapta asked.

"Do we *have* to? She was in such high spirits when she left earlier, it just feels mean to give her an update like this…" Scorpia spoke frantically, trying to find any positive outcome in this situation.

But Entrapta's worried look was enough to convince her otherwise. If they didn't tell her now, the guilt would eat away at the both of them.

Scorpia sighed. "I hate delivering bad news... I'll signal her to return."

As Scorpia went to the large fireplace on land to create the smoke signal, Entrapta looked into the distant forest and rivers. Somewhere out there was Catra, blissfully unaware of this painful discovery.

Entrapta sighed, resisting the urge to bite her fingernails and instead tugging at them to stimulate herself.

"Today of all days…"

---

Catra splashed the cool, refreshing water on her face, rubbing the dirt out of her cheeks and running her wetted fingers through her long hair.

The gentle creek was a perfect place to cool off for a few minutes, but for her companion, it was the opportunity for something else: a delicious meal.

Catra looked to her right to see her canine companion, Emily, looking intensely into the water, spotting a few fish swimming along with the stream.

There were a few seconds of silence as Emily followed the trail of one particularly big fish, licking her lips as she imagined the taste. She reared slightly, timing herself perfectly…

Before suddenly snatching her jaws at the creek, trying to sink her teeth into the fish.

But when she came up, the only thing she tasted was the water. And the only sight she saw was the fish rapidly escaping down the creek.

"Still need to work on your hunting skills, Emily," Catra smiled, reaching out a hand and stroking Emily's ear.

Emily was an adult Siberian husky, one of the many Catra kept on her ship. Although most of her dogs were well-trained, Emily needed a bit of extra help. A stop in Madeira was the perfect training session for her.

And it was the perfect way to celebrate Catra's twenty-eighth birthday.

Some alone-time with nature and a dog, a few hours to soak in the air and appreciate the sights, was all Catra needed for her birthday. Besides, later that night she'd be celebrating with her crew and getting her fair share of social interaction.

For now, it was peaceful.

Catra grabbed her large pack, slinging it around her shoulders and looking down at her companion. "Alright… I think we should head towards…"

As she looked around however, she soon noticed something in the distance. She squinted her eyes to get a good look, before finally spotting it.

It was a smoke signal coming from the direction of Fram, her ship. Three puffs of smoke, with a few seconds of delay between them.

Something required her attention.

"Scorpia, if you set the ship on fire already…" Catra sighed, mostly joking to herself.

Mostly.

Catra let out a quick, sharp whistle towards her companion. "Come on, Emily. Duty calls."

Emily barked in response, following at Catra's feet as she headed through the forest and back to the main river.

The birds sung around her in the forest, but as she headed further away, that sound was instead replaced by rushing water crashing against large boulders.

Although she had to walk all the way up here, the journey back to the ship would be much swifter thanks to her planning. The canoe she had dragged up all this way was still waiting patiently by the river.

Catra whistled twice in a row. "In the canoe, Em. We'll be back at Fram in no time."

Emily was more than happy to hop into the canoe, burying herself in the small boat and looking up at Catra with a smile as the captain tied her gear to the vessel.

Once everything was sorted, Catra placed her hands firmly on the canoe and gave it a heaping push, moving it through the mud with her strong arms, her biceps tensing.

But once the canoe was firmly in the water, Catra quickly leapt into it and grabbed the paddle sitting at the front, pushing the paddle against the river and guiding herself downstream towards Fram.

She only paddled a few times to avoid rocks and collisions with land. With all that spare time, she had a chance to take in the sights around her. The clear water, wet grass, brown dirt and dark trees.

In the distance, the mountains kissed the blue sky, snow covering their summits. Catra smiled as she looked to the beautiful clouds, covering the sun occasionally but always revealing the light after a few seconds.

She breathed in the sweet air through her nose, and let it out through her mouth. With not a single person in sight, and with only Emily to accompany her, Catra felt truly at peace.

Catra looked ahead to see a sudden drop in the river. Not dangerous, but certainly one she needed to brace for. She held the paddle against her chest, leaning back as the tip of the canoe went over the drop.

It submerged into the river with the landing, but quickly recovered and went back on track. Catra felt water splash on her face and spill into the canoe, but she appreciated the coolness against her body.

Emily was less appreciative of being covered in freezing water.

With only a few more strokes, Catra soon rounded the corner to see her ship, Fram, docked in the ocean where the river spilt out into. She turned left, driving the canoe into land and standing up, whistling twice for Emily to exit.

As she dragged the canoe towards the ship with Emily by her feet, she saw first mate and second mate Scorpia and Entrapta, respectively, approach her from the ship, both of them smiling in the most unconvincing manner Catra had ever seen.

The ship hadn't been set on fire, but Catra was already worried.

"Captain! How was your training session with Emily?" Scorpia asked, taking Catra's canoe for her and picking it up with one strong arm to carry.

"She's getting better at tracking and pulling weight, but her hunting could use some work," Catra replied.

The three of them crossed the small wooden bridge onto the ship. Catra clicked her tongue and Emily was quick to make her way down into the cargo hold with the rest of the dogs.

"Is something wrong with Fram?" Catra asked.

"She's in perfect condition, captain. Nothing to worry about!" Scorpia grinned.

Catra blinked. "Then why did you signal me like there was an emergency?"

"Oh! Well, it's not really an emergency, but…" Scorpia swallowed nervously, trying to keep her smile up. "I mean, we can just tell you later, right? It's your birthday! Bad news can always come later."

"Bad news?" Catra raised an eyebrow.

"Did I say bad news? I meant… Definitely mediocre news! That you don't have to worry about! Until tomorrow!"

Catra stopped in her path, sighing with some frustration.

"Entrapta, would you mind informing me of whatever our first mate is failing to get across?" Catra asked, looking to her second officer.

"I was… hoping Scorpia would tell you," Entrapta replied.

Catra pinched the bridge of her nose. "Can one of you, *please* just tell me what is going-"

"We got beaten, captain."

Catra's eyes shot open.

She looked up to Scorpia, who was finally able to blurt out the information. "We… what?" Catra asked.

"We got a report. Two people have already successfully reached the North Pole before us. Frederick Cook and Robert Peary," Scorpia spoke quickly and efficiently. "We… won't be the first to get there."

Catra took in the news, staring past Scorpia and looking at nothing in particular. She crossed her arms over her chest, tensing slightly under the weight of such a message.

"But… Hey, maybe we can be the *third* to get to the North Pole?" Scorpia smiled, trying to bring Catra's spirits up. "That's impressive, right?"

"I set out on this expedition to be the *first* to get to the North Pole, not the third," Catra spoke bluntly, pushing through the two officers and putting her hands on the railing to look down at the ocean.

Entrapta and Scorpia exchanged a worried glance.

"Well… Maybe we should return home?" Scorpia said. "Try and find another destination or a new objective?"

"It's not that simple. We're already low on funding, and this expedition needed to get results. They're going to take Fram away from us once we return," Catra shook her head.

"Maybe we should just never go back to Norway?" Entrapta suggested.

"We'd run out of supplies eventually. And the rest of the crew signed on for a reason," Catra replied, looking over her shoulder at the crew of over sixty people going about their tasks on the ship. "Let's just be blunt. We're fucked."

"… Sorry, captain," Scorpia spoke softly.

"It's not your fault, Scorpia. I appreciate you telling me this. Just…" Catra sighed. "Dammit."

Scorpia raised a hand to place on Catra's shoulder, but hesitated. Catra seemed too tense. Too upset. And her personal space was important to her in times like this.

Slowly, Scorpia drew her hand away.

"It'd be nice if we had gone to the South Pole instead. No one's been there yet," Entrapta perked up. "Plus, they have penguins there!"

"That'd be nice," Scorpia smiled sadly. But soon, she could only let out a dejected sigh. "Maybe we should've gone to someplace warm. Like Australia."

"There's no penguins in Australia…" Entrapta moped.

"Well…" Scorpia looked up, trying to smile for her captain. "Should we go inform the crew, captain? Get it over and done with?"

But no response came from Catra. She continued keeping her head hung low, her forehead pressed against her crossed arms.

"I… I get it. It's upsetting," Scorpia nodded. She turned to her crewmate. "Come on, Entrapta, we should leave her be."

But just as the two officers began to walk away, Catra spoke up with words that neither of them expected.

"… Entrapta, you're a fucking genius."

Catra had suddenly spoken, looking up from her misery and towards the ocean. Scorpia and Entrapta looked to their captain.

"Well, thank you!" Entrapta smiled. "I think you're very smart too, captain! That was a very sudden change from misery from compliments however, and I can't help but wonder where it came from!"

"You just gave us our new goal," Catra spoke with a breathless excitement, looking over her shoulder at her second mate. "I can't believe I didn't think of that earlier!"

"Uh…" Entrapta looked to Scorpia, nervously laughing. "Think of… Think of what?"

"Tell the crew to raise the anchor and be ready to depart," Catra instructed, heading frantically to her quarters. "We're making a slight detour on our trip."

"Captain, that sounds like a wonderful idea, it does, but *where* are we detouring to?" Scorpia called out.

Catra came to a stop, and when she turned to face her two mates, she had a grin on her face and a spark in her eye as she spoke her new destination.

"Antarctica."

---

Adora loved seeing her reflection in the rushing water below.

She could see the reflection of her hair, released from its ponytail and allowed to flow with the wind. She also saw the reflection of her outfit, a white button-up shirt with the sleeves rolled up and black suspenders around her shoulders.

She loved the feeling of the wind in her hair, blowing with the breeze. She loved the cool air on her skin. She loved the sound of her ship pushing through the ocean.

But most of all, she loved hearing the bells of the nearby dock.

It had been a few months since she departed from Wales, and after endless ocean for so long, it was a welcome sight to look up and see the land of New Zealand off in the horizon.

The Calliope Dock of the Devonport Naval Base would be where Adora would dock her ship, Terra Nova, for a month while she took shore leave. Being on solid land would be a nice change, and something the crew drastically needed.

And with land ahead, Adora had no time to waste. She quickly bunched her hair up into a ponytail and tied it securely as she went straight into captain mode.

“Send a message requesting permission to dock!” Adora called out to her crew, heading from the starboard side of her ship and towards the large mast at the front.

The crew responded with various affirmations, signalling the dock as Adora began to climb the large mast that stuck out of top of the ship.

Of course, not everyone was on board with her climbing something so tall.

“Captain, you *do* realise you don’t have to go up there, right?” Adora’s second mate, Bow, called out from below.

“I know,” Adora grunted as she climbed up the net to the highest point of the ship. She smiled down at Bow. “But this is where you get the best view!”

“You can’t…”

“Just let her,” another voice sounded next to Bow.

The second mate looked over to see his first mate and best friend, Glimmer, placing a hand on his shoulder. “It’s been months since we’ve seen land. I think she needs this,” Glimmer smiled.

“If she falls and gets herself killed…” Bow said with a hint of anxiety in his voice. “Why does no one ever care about ship safety?”

“Adora and safety don’t go hand-in-hand,” Glimmer shrugged.

Once Adora reached the highest point of the mast, she gripped onto the wooden pole, leaning to the side slightly and holding her hand above her eyes to shield the sun, looking to land.

The wind blew heavier up here, but Adora’s grip was strong. She narrowed her eyes, looking to the dock…

And finally, saw that familiar white flag being flown by a dock worker.

“Permission granted!” Adora called out in a loud voice to her crew. “All hands to docking stations!”

“Yes, sir!” Glimmer called out, going to her station.

“Please don’t fall!” Bow said afterwards.

Adora looked down at her crew rushing to their stations, readying the anchor and slowing the ship with the heavy amount of brake horsepower in Terra Nova. Her crew were hard-working and dedicated, and she couldn’t have had a better first and second mate.

This stop was the last step before her final stride towards her main goal.

After a few minutes of careful manoeuvring, the ship was steered into the dock and brought to a complete stop. Adora climbed down from the mast once the ship was finally stopped.

“Good work, everyone!” Adora called out as she dropped down to the deck once it was safe enough to do so. “Drinks are on me for whoever comes to the saloon tonight!”

That was enough to raise the spirits of her sixty-five-person crew.

Once a bridge was lowered between Terra Nova and the port, the crew began to make their way off the ship and into New Zealand for their one-month shore leave.

However, all was not so simple just yet.

Once Adora crossed the bridge, Glimmer quickly caught up with her. “I’ve got a message for you, captain.”

“Already?” Adora raised an eyebrow.

“Admiral Anderson has requested to speak with you at the dock before you leave.”

Adora let out a huff. “We’ve been at sea for four months. Can’t it wait?”

“Unfortunately not, sir. He promised it wouldn’t take long,” Glimmer replied.

“That’s what they always say,” Adora mumbled, before speaking up. “You and Bow go on ahead. I’ll catch up with you at the hotel.”

Glimmer nodded, and as she headed right with the rest of the crew to go into town, Adora turned left and went to her job.

Standing by the edge of the dock was the Admiral, wearing his Royal Navy uniform and a sense of superiority. Adora was still wearing her casual clothes, not exactly anticipating having to be so official this early.

“Captain Grayskull. I trust your journey was well?” Admiral Anderson spoke, extending a hand towards her.

Adora looked to the hand for a few seconds, and although her instincts told her to ignore it, she reluctantly shook it. “Smooth sailing, sir.”

“Glad to hear it,” Anderson smiled. “I just need to do a quick check, confirm a few things for my reports. It’s just a formality. My workers will be conducting some maintenance on your ship during your shore leave.”

“Of course, sir.” Adora tried to hide the annoyance in her voice.

Anderson scribbled down the date on his report mumbling to himself as he wrote. “October 28, 1910… State the name of your Royal Navy ship, Captain.”

“Terra Nova,” Adora replied.

“Names of first and second mate.”

“Glimmer Angelina and Bow Scribner.” Adora smiled faintly as she mentioned them.

“Give me a quick rundown of your cargo,” Anderson continued.

“Lab supplies, motorised sledges, four teams of huskies and half a dozen ponies, sir.”

“Ponies?” The Admiral looked up from his report.

“Yes, sir. Will that be a problem?” She asked with a hint of defiance in her voice.

The Admiral looked to her for a few more seconds, before shaking his head. “Confirm the objective of Terra Nova, Captain Grayskull.”

Adora looked to her ship with a proud glint in her eye as she spoke.

“Be the first to reach the South Pole, sir. Our destination is Antarctica.”

Even speaking it still didn’t feel real. It was a dream she’d had for the last fifteen years, but even at twenty-eight years old, she still

felt like a wonderous child when she reminded herself of her primary goal.

"Correction," the Admiral spoke. "Antarctica is your destination, yes, but your primary goal is scientific research, specifically the collection of wildlife and rock samples. Reaching the Pole was your *secondary* objective. Don't get ahead of yourself."

Adora bit her tongue, taking a sharp inhale. "Yes, sir."

Why the hell would he even ask in the first place if he was just going to tell her off anyway? Adora despised the way the British Royal Navy did things, but they gave her a ship and a chance to reach her dream destination. She followed along just for that.

"You also have another objective, captain. Can you correctly state that at least?" The Admiral asked.

"To locate Mara Hope, who has been MIA since the beginning of the Antarctic Winter," Adora spoke.

Mara Hope. Her childhood hero.

Mara was recently on another expedition in Antarctica but failed to report in when the Antarctic Winter hit back in March.

There was a hint of worry in the back of Adora's mind whenever she thought about it, but Adora was confident that someone as incredible as Mara would be able to handle the conditions.

"That'll be all, captain. Try not to lose sight of your goal to chase a blind dream," the Admiral concluded. "You're dismissed."

Adora had to resist the temptation to end the conversation on a venomous last note, instead keeping silent and heading away from the dock and towards town.

For the next month, she'd be waiting for the maintenance on her ship to be finished. That time could be spent training, studying, planning and preparing, all of which Adora was intending to do.

But for tonight, she needed to rest first, and head to the saloon with Bow and Glimmer later on. A four-month journey was no small feat, and she desperately needed to stretch her legs.

As she walked through the town covered in stores, homes and cobblestone, she kept thinking back to the date the Admiral wrote in his report.

October 28.

A familiar birthday for someone she hadn't seen in a long, long time.

Adora pressed a hand against her collarbone, almost as if feeling for it. That gift she received when she turned thirteen.

But it was gone. She hadn't had that silver ring in years. Perhaps it was thrown away for good by now.

Adora tried to forget her. But dates like this brought all those memories back. The memories of joy and of sorrow. The memories of excitement and disappointment.

The memories of her first and only love, Catra Horda.

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"Oh boy, Catra, if this is a joke, it's definitely the funniest one I've ever heard! I mean, you're not *really* considering travelling to the Antarctica out of nowhere, right? That's just crazy!"

Scorpia's worried rambling was mute in Catra's ears as she watched the anchor being drawn up. The grin on her face had still yet to go away.

"… Oh no she's serious," Scorpia soon realised as she watched Catra's smile.

"This is wonderful!" Entrapta beamed, cackling once more. "Antarctica has so much potential for research! So much potential for explorations! So much potential for penguins*!*"

"Oh, Entrapta, I am really, *really* happy for you, trust me, I am," Scorpia chuckled nervously, "but I think we need to remind ourselves that Antarctica is on the *other side of the planet*. How are we going to get there?"

"We have the supplies," Catra spoke up. "Of course, we might land ourselves into debt because of this, but being the first to reach the South Pole should give us more than enough funds to pay that off."

"Well…" Scorpia still felt tense, but seeing Catra's confidence and unwavering determination was enough to put her heart at some ease. "I'll follow you anywhere, captain. You know that! But the crew…"

"I'll convince the crew. You two just worry about turning this ship around," Catra spoke, leaving the two officers behind and heading to the front of the ship.

Scorpia's heart was still racing with anxiety, but when she looked down to Entrapta, she could see only excitement on her face as she bounced on her feet lightly.

Scorpia could only sigh, but she kept a strong heart and a stronger loyalty to her captain, going to her post to turn the ship hard to starboard.

As Scorpia and Entrapta went to work, Catra went to the front mast of the ship, climbing up slightly to get a good look at her crew. She took a deep breath.

"All eyes to me!"

Her commanding voice boomed out through the ship. Every hand on deck looked up to their captain, some with confusion, most with respect.

"We've just received some news that's led us to having a change of plan!" Catra called out. "This ship isn't heading to the North Pole anymore! We're making a slight detour!"

“Where to, captain?” A crew member asked.

She felt her heart beating, her body shaking, but she pushed through and spoke their new goal.

“Antarctica! We’re going to be the first to reach the South Pole!”

Silence waved throughout the ship.

Catra looked to her crew, seeing them process this for a few seconds. Some thought Catra was joking, whilst others thought they hadn’t heard her right. Absolutely everyone was speechless, until soon enough, one of her crew finally spoke up.

“Captain, are you mad?”

“I *would* be mad if I let us go any further on our current trip!” Catra replied. “The North Pole has already been conquered, and we can no longer be the first to reach it. If we keep going on this path, we return to Norway as failures and we lose our funding as well as this ship!”

The crew looked to each other with a bit of stunned silence upon learning that news.

“But captain,” another crew member called out, “the British are already heading for the South Pole! They sent a ship called Terra Nova out to be the first to reach it!”

“So we’ll beat them to it!” Catra answered without a hint of hesitation, causing murmurs among the crew and worried looks.

“Beat them? They already have months of a head start!”

“The British are tied down in regulations and rules. They’re only there for scientific research,” Catra continued as she lowered herself from the mast, walking down to be with her crew. “*We* aren’t tied down by anything, are we?”

“No, we aren’t!” Scorpia called out, encouraging her captain.

"So while they're busy collecting rocks, we'll sneak in behind them, reach the Pole, and kick them in the ass on the way out! Science will just have to look after itself!" Catra declared. "I guarantee you that they've had to make multiple stops for their expeditions! We won't be too late if we turn back now and make a straight path for the Antarctic!"

The crew were slowly starting to see Catra's point. She had to keep going. Get them on board. She walked among her crew, and yet stood taller than the rest through respect alone.

"Way I see it, we have two options from where we proceed," Catra spoke loudly. "We keep going on this journey, we only become the third to reach the North Pole, no one remembers us, and we lose our ship."

The crew didn't seem to like that idea.

"Or…" Catra grinned. "We make the turn now, be the first to reach the South Pole, land ourselves in the history books and become fucking legends! We *know* how to do this! We've trained ourselves for polar conditions! We know how to use the dogs and how to use the skis!"

"The British don't know the first thing about dogs or skis! I read that they're relying on motorised sledges!" A younger crew member spoke up.

"Exactly right! We're better than them, we're smarter, we're faster, and we damn well know we're going to win this. If it's a race to the South Pole, it won't even be a competition," Catra grinned. "I know each and every one of you. What your strengths are, what your potential is. One of you is worth twenty Royal Navy soldiers alone."

Catra scanned the face of every single one of her crew members, glancing up at Scorpia and seeing her flashing a thumbs-up.

"So I'm going to ask you this," Catra came to a stop. "Are you with me?"

Catra heard the large agreement among her crew, but she could only scoff.

"I said…" She took a breath. "ARE YOU WITH ME?!" Catra roared.

The cheers of her crew was a beautiful sound, and Catra nodded with a wide grin.

"That's what I like to hear! Now be ready to turn this ship around and make way for Antarctica!" Catra commanded.

With the crew confidently on their way to their stations, Catra soon saw Entrapta approach her with few scraps of paper thrown together with what she had.

"I've compiled the best report I could get with what I have on Terra Nova if you wanted to see it, captain," Entrapta said, following Catra as she went around to check on her crew.

"Give me the short version," Catra said.

"We know it's a wooden-hulled barque with one funnel and three masts," Entrapta spoke. "She's got a compound steam engine and is about 180 feet in length."

"What's the crew like?" Catra asked, patting one of her crewmates on the back to confirm a job well done.

"Sixty-five strong, and they're led by captain Adora Grayskull. I don't have much information on her, but… Catra?"

Catra had stopped.

Entrapta could see that her booming confidence had grinded to a halt, her eyes wide and her breath cut short. It was like someone had shot her.

It was a state Entrapta had never seen her captain in. Sure, Catra had been surprised about things in the past, such as Scorpia managing to carry three whole canoes at once. But this was more

than surprise.

This was shock.

Seeing Catra's expression, Entrapta felt a wave of guilt and yet she didn't know why. In the back of her mind was one question: What had she said wrong this time? She tried to analyse her words to piece together where she screwed up.

But suddenly, Catra muttered one word.

"Adora..."

The captain's voice sounded unlike anything Entrapta had heard. It was a mix of horror, sorrow and... regret.

Entrapta could see Catra's heterochromatic eyes unfocused as her brain tried to process this news.

Entrapta was never good in these situations. She cleared her throat to fill the silence, though she was slowly regretting every action she made. Why could she never get anything right?

"Wow… I wasn't aware that captain Grayskull was so intimidating, even to you, captain," Entrapta noted. "Fascinating… I'll go see what I can find on her."

"That... won't be necessary, Entrapta. I have all the information I need."

Catra's voice was distant.

"You already know Adora Grayskull?" Entrapta asked.

Catra looked out to the ocean with a cold gaze.

"I used to."

Entrapta wasn't quite sure how to process that response.

“You and Scorpia tend to the crew and get this ship going,” Catra spoke in an authoritative voice as she began to head for her quarters. “I need to send a telegram.”

Entrapta was left in confused silence as Catra made her way downstairs and into her quarters, quickly preparing to send her message.

Her whole world felt like it had been flipped upside-down by the mere mention of a name.

A name she had tried to block out for years.

As she went to tap in her morse code for her telegram, she glanced over to her treasured items in the corner of her room. She tried to stop herself from looking, but it was no use.

Among her treasured items were small model ships, souvenirs from her other expeditions, a few colourless photographs of herself and the crew…

And atop all those possessions was a small silver ring.

---

The temperatures taken by previous research teams in Antarctica, including Mara Hope’s team from a few years back, was some of the most important data Adora could get her hands on.

She studied the chart in her hands, planning her course in her mind. Adora was *always* planning ahead for every situation. It’s one of the reasons she was promoted to captain.

Most notable on her Antarctic temperature chart was the sudden drop from 0 degrees Celsius in January to -25 in March and then -35 April. March is around when the Antarctic Winter starts, when the sun sets and doesn’t rise for nearly seven months.

She carefully considered this into her plan, placing a hand over her mouth to process this, until suddenly…

“Hello? Adora? You still with us?”

Glimmer’s voice interrupted her.

Adora looked up. “Huh?”

“Come on, Adora. You can ease up for tonight at the very least. Have a drink,” Glimmer smiled, nudging a pint towards her. “You earned it.”

Adora looked around to see most of her crew at various points in the saloon. She almost completely forgotten where she was, and hearing the sudden piano and various forms of conversation around her was enough to snap her back into the real world.

“Why’d you bring your research? You don’t have to worry about that for another month,” Glimmer queried.

“Hey, it never hurts to have a plan for everything,” Adora replied, pocketing the chart. “I was trying to get a sense of the temperature down there. Plan our dates.”

“Can you give us a rundown?” Bow asked, indulging into Adora’s obsession. He liked hearing Adora talk about everything she had researched.

“We should be arriving around early January, but our main goal at the start will be laying out supply depots before winter hits in March. We won’t actually be trekking to the Pole until the winter is over,” Adora explained as she leaned her elbows against the table. “We’ll also need to find where Mara Hope is before winter sets in and confirm her status.”

“You think she’s okay?” Glimmer asked, her eyebrows narrowing.

“She’s been to Antarctica three times before. I’m sure she’s just having trouble with communications. We know where her base is, so it shouldn’t take long to find her,” Adora spoke with a sense of confidence in her voice.

"So after we find her, we wait out the winter ourselves?" Bow confirmed.

Adora nodded. "From March until October, November at the latest. Once the sun is up and the temperature has risen a bit, we'll begin our journey to the South Pole. Get there, get back, go home, and get our names in the history books."

"Oh, but you *must* remember Adora, we're here for 'scientific research' and the Pole is a 'secondary objective'. Don't get so ahead of yourself," Glimmer spoke in the most *exaggerated* posh accent.

Adora snickered. "That Admiral can go fuck himself. It's been my childhood dream to get to the South Pole, I'm not here for rocks!"

"Hey, *some* of us here actually like researching those rocks," Bow insisted. "There's some fascinating flora that can be found in Antarctica! Mosses, liverworts, fungi, all specially adapted to survive in extreme environments."

"If you like doing all that research, then I'm happy for you. But I'm here for two things," Adora spoke, raising her hand up and counting them on her fingers. "One: Being the first to get to the South Pole. And two: Seeing Aurora Australis."

"That's a specific goal," Glimmer replied. "Where'd you get that latter one from?"

"It's… just something I've wanted to do since I was thirteen. Not much to it," Adora shrugged, taking a drink from her pint and avoiding the subject.

It wasn't the truth. But Adora didn't particularly feel like sharing the truth of that matter.

"Still, they should let you make the Pole your primary objective," Bow agreed. "I don't understand why they're so insistent on science above all else. Even I think they should prioritise the Pole."

"Trust me, if I could find some way to get to Antarctica without having to enlist in the Navy and go through all the bullshit, I'd go for that alternative in a heartbeat," Adora admitted. "I only joined because of my family. Long line of people who've served in armed forces. It was just an expectation from birth."

"Pressured, huh?" Glimmer asked, to which Adora nodded. "I'm not much better. I only joined because I was sick of people underestimating me."

"Is that right?" Adora asked.

Glimmer held out her hands, clenching her fists. "I just wanted to… prove to my family and everyone around me that I could do great things. That I wasn't some prim and proper girl who was too afraid to get my hands dirty. And all those Royal Navy posters on the street said that I could really prove myself here."

"They hit you hard with that propaganda as soon as they can," Adora scoffed. "Bow, you joined with her, didn't you?"

Bow looked to Glimmer with a soft smile, before looking back to Adora. "Wherever she goes, I go. I suppose I wanted to prove myself to my parents as well. Plus, I was afraid that if Glimmer spent too long on her own, she'd probably kill someone."

"Oh, I wouldn't *kill* anyone," Glimmer chuckled, punching Bow in the arm gently. "I'd just correct someone if they tried to fuck with me. I would do just fine without you!"

"Didn't you say you were happy to have a friend enlisting with you?" Bow asked. "Something about how you could never have made it through training without me by your side?"

"Okay, well… Shut up, I was being dramatic," Glimmer huffed, taking a sip from her drink and turning to face away from Bow.

"Hey," Bow smiled, placing a hand on Glimmer's shoulder. "I couldn't have made it without you, either. You really helped when things got rough."

Glimmer tried to remain silent and keep her gaze directed towards the floor, though it did little to hide the slight blush that washed through her face.

"In the end, it's not the *worst* job ever," Bow said, taking his hand away from Glimmer's shoulder. "Being able to go to new places is a nice bonus."

"I suppose…" Adora sighed.

Being in the Navy wasn't exactly daily suffering, and being given the opportunity to go to Antarctica was the best thing to come out of enlisting.

But Adora never felt quite right in the Royal Navy. There was a deep sense of disgust, self-doubt and fear that came from being enlisted. Feelings she'd been stuck with for the past eight years.

She shouldn't have even been here in the first place.

Before she could sink any further into those thoughts, the door to the saloon swung open. All eyes glanced to the door, and Adora placed her drink down to look.

There, she saw a member of her crew, who walked towards her and handed her a small letter.

"Telegram for you, captain. It comes from Madeira."

Adora raised an eyebrow, but she accepted the telegram nonetheless from her crew member, who gave a quick salute upon handing the message over, before swiftly leaving.

Adora never really like people saluting her, but it was something that was trained into her crew from day one. It was difficult to unlearn.

Flipping the letter over, she saw a small message. Only a few words translated from morse code.

And yet those small words were enough to nearly knock the air out of her.

‘**Beg leave to inform you Fram proceeding Antarctica – Catra’**.

Bow and Glimmer glanced at the message as Adora held it out. There was a silence between the three of them as they took in the words.

To Bow and Glimmer, it meant one thing.

“So… Someone’s going to be at Antarctica with us, huh?” Bow observed.

“Maybe they’re trying to beat us to the South Pole?” Glimmer asked. “I don’t see why else they’d send this message.”

But to Adora, it meant another thing entirely.

“Catra…”

She let that name escape her lips with a soft gasp.

Bow and Glimmer looked to their captain with concern, and Adora knew she’d have to explain herself.

“It’s Catra. The one who sent the letter. I know her. She… She was my…” Adora contemplated for a few seconds, trying to find the right word to say. But she ultimately had to settle on a lie.

“… she was my friend.”

“*Was* your friend?” Glimmer asked.

Adora nodded, placing the message face down on the table. “We… had a falling out. Right when I joined the Navy. I haven’t seen her in years.”

Bow and Glimmer exchanged a short, worried glance. “What happened between you two?” Bow asked gently, trying to

navigate the sensitive subject.

“It’s…” Adora blinked. She looked to the table for a few seconds, before shaking her head. “It’s hard to explain.”

“That’s okay. Take your time,” Bow reassured. “Do you need to step outside?”

“… Yes,” Adora nodded. “You two stay here. I just need to gather my thoughts.”

She quickly stood up from the table without a glance back at Glimmer and Bow, making her way out of the saloon and into the night, seeing the dimly lit streets and a couple of horse-led carriages trot their way down the cobblestone path.

Adora looked to the letter in her hand. The first words Catra had sent to her in eight years. Only short, simple ones, but they carried a heavy weight behind them.

“Catra…”

Adora looked up to the night sky. She looked to the stars, and the bright moon. Perhaps Catra was looking to that very same moon at that exact moment.

Adora took a breath.

Catra would be in Antarctica. She’d be heading towards the South Pole as well, and soon enough, the two of them would cross paths. There was no avoiding it.

At some point, Adora would have to confront her sorrowful history.

And their broken
promise.

# Promise Part 2

Chapter Summary

A memory of a tense first encounter and a continued lie. In the present day, Scorpia and Catra share a few secrets, and Adora sets sail for the land of her dreams.

Chapter Notes

Hey y'all! Thanks so much for the support on the first chapter! I noticed many familiar readers leaving their amazing comments, and I can't thank y'all enough for it. But if this is your first story of mine, that's great too! I love seeing everyone's thoughts, and I'll always respond to comments <3

Quick note, this chapter and the next were meant to be one big chapter, but I ended up writing an almost 12,000 word chapter (whoops). In the interest of time and narrative, I decided to split them. That means the total chapter counter has risen to 21, and the next chapter (chapter 3) will be posted soon, within the next few days.

In the meantime, I hope you enjoy this one!

*November 6, 1898.*

The sixteen-year-old Catra was really starting to hate the dress she was wearing.

She hated the way the corset around her waist almost forced her body into an S-shape. She hated that the dress was too long for her, dragging by her feet and nipping at her heels occasionally. She *especially* hated how it exposed her upper arms and collarbone to the cool air, sending shivers through her body occasionally.

But she had to look nice. After all, she had been invited to talk with her girlfriend's parents that evening.

She stood outside the front door of Adora's home, reaching towards the small string by the front door and tugging it. She could hear a bell within the house ring with each tug.

It only took a few seconds for Catra to hear footsteps approaching the front door, and she put her hands behind her back, expecting either of Adora's parents to open the door.

She had met with Adora's parents a few times, but only briefly. Having dinner with them was a whole other task.

But when the front door opened, Catra was instead met with Adora's beautiful blue eyes looking right at her. Curiosity changed into joy when Adora saw who was at her door.

"Catra!" Adora smiled, wrapping her arms around her partner and holding her close. "You look great!"

"I don't *feel* great…" Catra muttered, returning the hug nonetheless. "This dress is choking me to death."

"Trust me, I know the feeling," Adora replied.

Catra noticed in that moment that Adora was wearing a dress of her own, though whilst Catra's was entirely black, Adora's was more of a deep red.

"At least we're suffering together," Catra chuckled.

"After dinner, I can give you some of my clothes to change into," Adora promised, separating from her. "You're staying the night, yes?"

"Why wouldn't I?" Catra smirked. "I still don't understand why your parents want to talk to me so desperately, however."

"I'm not sure either. They haven't told me anything," Adora replied. "Just be warned, my dad is a *little* intense sometimes, but I'm sure you'll be fine."

Catra couldn't help but feel a tad nervous. She quickly took Adora's hand in her own to feel some sort of comfort, rubbing her thumb over her partner's palm. "As long as I have you, I know everything will be fine."

Adora smiled down at her and Catra's hands together, before looking up into Catra's loving eyes. It was only the briefest of glances, but it was everything she needed.

Adora looked behind herself quickly to make sure no one was watching. In the span of a couple of seconds, she then quickly leaned in and pressed her lips to Catra's, giving her a small kiss.

Her partner was quick to return it, closing her eyes and accepting Adora's kiss. She squeezed Adora's hand as she tilted her head and embraced her love.

"Just for good luck," Adora whispered as she separated.

Catra nodded. She took her hand away from Adora's and walked towards the dining area.

Along the way, she looked around at the décor, including some lovely furniture and intricate wallpaper. Upon those very walls were a few realistic paintings of various men and women, all of them hung up around the hall leading into the dining area.

Catra had been to Adora's house in the past, but it was often a quick trip upstairs to her bedroom. She had never gotten the chance to fully explore her home, so seeing these paintings was all new to her.

Each portrait had a person in some sort of military uniform, and each of those people had the last name of Grayskull. Some were soldiers, some were captains, some were admirals.

Catra stopped for a few seconds to look at all the portraits, trying to compare each person to what Adora looked like and attempting to spot any similarities.

"I see Miss Horda's already taken notice of our family's history," a sudden masculine voice sounded from Catra's right.

Catra jolted suddenly, looking over to see an older man with thin blonde hair and eyes similar to Adora's in the dining area. He had a prideful smile as he looked to Catra, approaching her slowly and extending a hand.

"Randor Grayskull. I'm Adora's father," he said. His voice was low and crackly, almost vibrating from deep within his chest.

Catra didn't hesitate as she took Randor's hand in her own, shaking it quickly and withdrawing just as fast. "It's nice to meet you, Mr. Grayskull."

"Just Randor is fine," the older man chuckled. He nodded up to one of the portraits. "*That* is Mr. Grayskull up there."

Catra looked up to the painting to see an older general with little hair on his head and a rough beard, his glare intense and his uniform fitted tightly around his chest.

"Is that your father?" Catra asked Randor.

"That he is. Served in the Navy for the better part of fifty years," Randor said with pride in his voice. "All of these portraits you see are the pride of the Grayskull's. The men and women who devoted their lives to our great country."

"I see…" Catra replied.

She looking to Randor to see his expression. A gentle smile, not too great, but firm enough. He admired the paintings as if he had created them himself.

"Oh Randor, Catra only *just* arrived. The house tour can come later," a more feminine voice sounded from within the dining area.

Catra looked over to see a woman, sporting longer, darker hair and wrinklier skin, with crow's feet haunting her eyes. Yet, the spring in her step contradicted her older look.

"Catra looked interested, Marlena. What's wrong with discussing a bit of family history?" Randor asked the woman, who Catra assumed to be his wife.

"At least let the poor girl eat something first," the woman named Marlena spoke firmly, before looking to Catra and softening her expression. "Come have a seat, dear. We prepared some roasted duck."

"Oh… Thank you," Catra spoke as she saw the still steaming bird placed in the middle of the large dining table.

She went took a seat next to Adora on one end of the table. She couldn't help but notice how long the table was, enough to seat three whole families. She felt small compared to the rest of the room.

As Randor and Marlena took their seats, Catra glanced over to Adora, as if to check on how they were doing.

Adora smiled softly.

"I have to say, Catra, your dress looks wonderful," Marlena spoke as Catra plated herself some of the food. "Who made it for you?"

"Oh, it's… just one that my mother used to have," Catra replied. "It's a bit firm, but the colour is nice."

"Your mother's? You don't have a dress of your own?" Marlena asked, raising an eyebrow.

"I… don't wear dresses that often," Catra admitted, not really seeing in the harm in that statement.

It’s not that Catra hated dresses. If it didn’t squeeze the life out of her, she’d even appreciate wearing one and she could probably pull it off with style. But the restriction of movement and the harm to her spine was too much of a price to pay to look presentable.

However, that statement seemed to bewilder Marlena. “A girl your age without a dress of your own? You have *got* to get that fixed soon.”

Catra let out a weak chuckle. “I’ll make sure of it,” she spoke, though she didn’t really mean it.

“Catra can wear what she likes, mom,” Adora spoke up as she picked at her food, a tone of annoyance in her voice. “It’s not your place to judge.”

“Well, I wasn’t *judging*,” Marlena defended herself, but Adora could only sigh.

“So, Catra,” Randor spoke up before Marlena and Adora could go any further. “Did you read about what happened at the United States today? It was all over the papers.”

“The gas explosion at the Capitol?” Catra replied, raising an eyebrow. “Well, I’m just glad no one was hurt.”

“It really is the result of stupidity, isn’t it?” Randor chuckled. “They were using both gas and electricity to light the damn building! You can’t just *transition* from gas to electricity. You have to be using one or the other. Using both… it was always inevitable.”

Catra wasn’t sure how to respond to that. She tensed her grip on her fork slightly, finding the topics of conversations more and more discomforting.

She could only hope these were just awkward first impressions.

“Randor, I *really* don’t think that’s something to discuss at dinner table,” Marlena insisted.

“And talking about your dresses is?” Randor responded quickly with some sarcasm in his voice.

Oh no. It was getting worse.

Catra felt herself shrinking slightly, looking between the two adults who were bickering like children, her face expressing both confusion and an incessant need to leave as soon as possible.

“I think there’s a stark contrast between talking about eveningwear and an *explosion*, don’t you?” Marlena asked.

“It’s to do with current events!” Randor threw a hand up. “Catra clearly seems more interested in-“

“Oh, so you’re finally discussing current events for the first time! A nice change of pace from your constant talk about our family history, since that’s the only damn thing that matters to you.”

Oh, this was going to *shit.*

Catra felt her heart racing. “It’s fine, you two… I don’t-“

“You know how much it costs to have all those portraits done?” Randor cut Catra off. “And not once have you ever stopped to appreciate them! Those people fought for our country, some even died for it! Show some damn respect!”

“I never *asked* for our house to be flooded with portraits. In fact, I’ve never been asked anything! You just decide everything and just assume no one should dare challenge you because you’re always right all the time!”

“Who gave you the right to raise your voice at-“

“For god’s sake, *stop!*”

Adora’s loud and sudden authoritative roar even jolted Catra in her seat. A roar accompanied by the *clang* of metal against the porcelain plate.

All eyes in the building glanced towards Adora, who had dropped her knife and fork on her plate with a bit of force.

"Adora, careful," Marlena quickly pointed out, raising a finger. "Those plates are delicate."

"You two…" Adora took a deep, frustrated breath. "You both *insisted* I invited Catra over. I thought we could have a *normal* dinner for once, but just like always, you're arguing," Adora seethed, her eyes glaring at her parents. "Was there some point in Catra joining us or should I escort her home?"

Catra saw an expression on Adora's face she had rarely seen before. Her narrow eyebrows, wrinkled nose and downturned lips. Adora wasn't just angry; she was *pissed.*

"Well…" Marlena forced a smile. "We were hoping to discuss something with Catra. But it can wait until after dinner-"

"Actually, it can't," Adora interrupted her. "I'm not going to sit here for another second and wait for you two to melt down again. Say to Catra whatever it is you want to say."

The husband and wife looked to each other, and they both knew this was only going one direction.

Randor took a deep breath in through his nose. "Catra, we were… curious as to what you were planning to do with yourself in the future."

Catra felt herself slightly caught off guard. She certainly wasn't the question she was expecting.

"Well…" Catra cleared her throat. "I was thinking of going to Norway for a short time. That's where I was born and raised for the first four years of my life."

"Yes, that's your *immediate* future. But what about your long-term plans?" Randor asked. "Goals? Aspirations?"

"Dad, do you really have to interrogate…"

"There's a point to this, Adora," Randor cut her off.

Catra glanced to Adora for a bit, before looking back to the man. "I was going to join a few expeditions out to sea. Get some experience and travel the world."

"That's it? Just… get on a boat and travel the world?" Randor asked, his tone expressing disbelief as he raised an eyebrow. "You think it's that easy?"

"I'm not saying it'll be easy," Catra replied, not letting the older man intimidate her. "I'm saying that I *will* do it. One way or another."

Randor looked to his wife for a few seconds, and slowly, his lips curled upwards into a smile. "Well, Catra… Allow me to *make* it easy for you. I wanted to extend an offer to you. One that I know you'll like."

Catra wasn't sure how to feel about that smile. She wasn't sure how to feel about anything that was happening this evening.

Slowly, Catra felt a warmth over hand. It didn't take long for her to realise Adora was holding her hand under the table. Adora's hands were shaking.

Catra quickly intertwined her fingers with Adora's, keeping it hidden from their parents and soothing her, rubbing her thumb over her partner's palm.

"You and Adora… You're good friends. We know that much," Randor said. "Adora has always been a better person around you. And we like that, Marlena and I, we really do."

"Dad… Where's this going?" Adora asked.

"Adora is planning to join the Royal Navy when she turns twenty," Randor continued, ignoring his daughter. "And we just know she'll

do good. Military service is in her blood."

Randor took a breath. "But we know she'll do even better… if she's with you."

It took a few seconds for Catra to decipher what Randor was saying, but it took half that time for Adora to realise it all.

Before anyone could respond, Adora had suddenly stood up, her chair's legs scraping against the marble floor.

"Are… Are you trying to enlist Catra in the Navy?!"

"We know she was born in Norway and that might complicate things," Randor said, tilting his head from side to side. And yet his smile remained firm. "But I'm sure we can figure a workaround. There's nothing better than serving the greatest country in the world."

Catra didn't even respond. Adora was doing it for her.

"You can't be fucking serious!" Adora cried out.

"Language!" Marlena spoke up.

"Adora, I don't see why you're so upset," Randor spoke with a tense tone as he stood up. "Wouldn't enlisting with Catra be a good thing? You've been whinging about having to enlist by yourself. With Catra there, you would at least have some familiar company-"

"You made me invite Catra over just so she could join your stupid *fucking* Navy?!" Adora gawked. "Because you haven't manipulated enough people to join yet?!"

"For the last time, Adora, the posters that we put up aren't manipulation-"

"Oh, shut up!" Adora snapped, before burying her face in her hands and growling. "God, why am I even surprised? You've never

cared about me or my friends! You just care about us taking up a gun and doing whatever some admiral tells us to!”

“Dear, would you at least let Catra speak?” Marlena insisted as she stood up, directing a hand to the guest. “Your shouting is making her uncomfortable. A lady should never shout or use such *vile* language.”

”Oh, *piss off*-“

“I agree!” Randor nodded to his wife. “Catra, what say you in all this? Surely you see the good in this offer.”

In less than a second, all eyes went to Catra, the only one still *sitting* at the dinner table. She looked between the two adults and Adora, the hostility in the air almost choking her. She could’ve sworn they were hearing her heart punching at her chest.

Out of the thousand possibilities she imagined in her head, *this* wasn’t how she expected the night to go. But given everything that had happened, and especially given the way they treated Adora, there was only *one* way it was ending.

Silently, she grabbed the napkin laid upon her lap and wiped her mouth with it, scrunching it up and placing it on the table. She stood up, stepping away from the table and pushing the chair back in with some elegance.

“Thanks for the duck,” Catra spoke plainly. “I think I’ll be heading home now. Adora, could you escort me?”

”Certainly,” Adora nodded, sharing one last death stare with her father before turning away from him and towards Catra.

“Catra, don’t you have an answer for us?” Randor asked. “Serving our country is a great honour, and-”

“My apologies, Mr. Grayskull,” Catra cut him off as she began to head for the front door, her heels clacking against the marble

floor. “But quite frankly, I have an incredibly *low* tolerance for bullshit. Good evening to you.”

Randor’s voice caught in his throat as he tried to respond to that. He could only look to the sixteen-year-old girl in shock as she simply walked away with more elegance than either of them had presented that evening.

Adora was quick to follow, giving off one last glare to Randor, before turning and heading straight out the door and onto the streets.

Neither Randor nor Marlena followed behind either of them as they left Adora’s home. Catra’s house was about ten minutes on foot, and for the first few minutes, they simply walked in silence.

Catra was slowly getting used to the sound of their heels against the cobblestone. The gentle breeze of the English weather. The occasional clops of horseshoes against the road when a carriage travelled by.

But soon enough, all of that was interrupted by two quiet words from Adora.

“I’m sorry.”

Catra looked to Adora to see her face downcast. “What are you sorry about?” Catra asked. “None of that was your fault.”

“I had a feeling my father would do something like that. I should’ve known he’d try to…” Adora sighed.

“Screw him. He doesn’t get to control you and he sure as hell doesn’t get to control me,” Catra smiled, putting a hand on Adora’s shoulder. “We’ve already got our future planned. You still have that ring, right?”

“I do,” Adora nodded. “But…”

“But…?”

Adora struggled to find the right words to say. She started a sentence twice before she finally gave up trying to sugar-coat it.

"What he said about me planning to join the Navy… He wasn't wrong about that."

Catra's expression dropped. She slid her hand away from Adora's shoulder and came to a stop. "What do you mean?"

"I want to go to the South Pole. I want to see Aurora Australis with you." Adora sighed, gripping her wrist. "But it's not as simple as just getting a boat and deciding to go. The real world is more complicated than that."

Catra's words caught in her throat. "Are you saying you don't want to go anymore?"

"Of course not. I'm keeping that promise to you," Adora reaffirmed. "It's just difficult to do. And joining the Navy at least gives us some more options."

"Hold on. *Us?*" Catra raised an eyebrow.

"Catra, I'm not saying-"

"You just screamed at your father about this and now you're doing the exact same thing he is?" Catra asked. "Trying to enlist me in some military to serve a country I despise?"

"That's not what I'm saying. Just listen to me," Adora spoke quickly. "*You* don't have to join the Navy or anything. But that's what *I'm* planning to do. *I'll* be able to find us a way to get to the South Pole together. Besides, it's not like I have much of a choice given my family history. One way or another, I'm going to end up in uniform."

"How are we going to go *together* if *you're* in the Navy?" Catra shook her head. "That doesn't make sense, Adora."

"We'll find a way. We'll figure it out, just like we always have," Adora smiled, cupping Catra's cheek with the palm of her hand. "Don't you trust me?"

"I do, but…" Catra put her hand over Adora's. "Is this what *you* want, Adora? Enlisting in the Navy just to keep our promise… Is that *really* what you want to do?"

Adora immediately nodded without any sense of self-care. "It is."

It wasn't the truth. But Adora lied for Catra's happiness. Her smile was all that mattered.

Catra stayed silent for a few seconds, gripping Adora's hand. Slowly, she took a deep breath, before letting it out and pushing her forehead against Adora's.

"Okay," Catra whispered. "I trust you."

Adora smiled, raking her fingers through Catra's hair to soothe her, her fingers gentle massaging Catra's scalp. "We'll figure things out. It'll be worth it when we see Aurora Australis."

Catra chuckled. She brought her arms up and wrapped them around Adora, holding her close and burying her face into the crook of her neck. "I love you."

Adora returned the hug, rubbing circles around Catra's back and resting her chin on her partner's shoulder. "I love you, too."

But deep within her heart, Adora was filled with doubt.

Doubt over the future. Doubt over their way of getting to the South Pole. Doubt over joining the Navy.

She was doing this for Catra's happiness. For their promise. But as time went on, she was realising just how hard it was going to be to keep that promise.

Still, she kept a smile. She had to. Adora had to keep pushing to realise their dream.

Even if she had to lie sometimes along the way in order to avoid hurting Catra.

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*November 6, 1910.*

Catra held up the silver ring, looking at the scratches it had gotten over the last fifteen years.

Battle scars. Wear and tear. Whatever people called it, it was oddly fitting. The ring was in a lesser state than when Catra got her hands on it all those years ago.

In a way, it was a fitting image of the promise it was meant for.

Suddenly, Catra heard three knocks rapidly against her quarter doors. It jolted her out of daydreaming of the past, and she quickly pocketed the ring, standing up from her bed and heading for the heavy door.

She opened it to reveal her first mate, Scorpia, standing on the other side with a comforting smile. "Evening, captain."

"Scorpia," Catra nodded. "Is it already time for cargo check?"

"Sure is, captain," Scorpia said. "It's a funny story, actually. I was waiting for you by the stairs but then you weren't coming, and I was thinking 'is today Thursday or did I mix up my dates again?', so I went to check the calendar and sure enough, it's Thursday! Then I figured 'Hmm, maybe the cargo check has changed to another date' and I went to go ask Entrapta, but she was in the middle of researching chinstrap penguins, whatever those are. So then I realised 'oh gosh, maybe the captain is late!' and then I went to go check on you and-"

"Thank you, Scorpia," Catra cut her off. "That'll be all. Sorry for not showing up. I was just… distracted."

“Oh, that’s okay, captain!” Scorpia grinned. “Something on your mind?”

“A few things.”

Catra walked past Scorpia and out of her quarters, heading towards the stairs that would take her to a lower level of the ship: the cargo hold.

The night sky was filled with stars and a moon that lit their path ahead. The ocean surrounded Fram, and yet she kept on sailing, pushing through the calm waters.

They’d left Madeira a week ago and were on a straight path to Antarctica. The crew were all on board by now, with some even preferential to the new location.

But Catra had been thinking about other events in the meantime.

“Well, when I have something on my mind, I like to speak about it with a friend! I think that usually helps me,” Scorpia gleefully said as she descended down into the cargo hold with Catra. “Now I’m not saying that’s what you *have* to do, I’m just saying that it’s an option.”

Catra looked to the packs of husky dogs they kept. Four teams of them, most of them sleeping with Emily being the odd one out like usual, her excited face looking to Catra.

“All the dogs are accounted for,” Catra spoke. “And… I’m not so sure about talking. It’s hard to explain why I’ve been so distracted.”

“Well, I could certainly *try* to understand!” Scorpia smiled. “And even if I can’t, just getting it off your chest might help too.”

Catra looked to the skis, big enough to hold their supplies, with ropes attached to the front for the dogs to pull.

“Skis are in working order,” Catra said once more. “And I need you to promise that whatever I tell you stays between us. The crew hearing about the captain having personal issues could lower morale.”

“Oh, I’m excellent at keeping secrets!” Scorpia grinned. “I used to travel with this guy, Kyle, and he told me he had a crush on this other girl, Lonnie, and I never told a soul!”

Catra looked to Scorpia.

“Until now!”

The captain sighed. She was never good at talking about her feelings. But it’s not like anyone else was offering to listen to her personal problems.

Besides. Scorpia wasn’t going to drop this until they talked.

With the cargo check done, Catra turned to face Scorpia, taking a seat on one of the wooden boxes.

“Do you know the captain of Terra Nova?” Catra asked.

“Of course. Adora Grayskull, decorated captain of the Royal Navy,” Scorpia responded, sitting down on a box opposite Catra. “What kind of name is Adora, anyway? It’s like, okay, we get it, everyone loves you. But you know what? I sure don’t. That name just irks me.”

“Adora and I… We have a history,” Catra explained. “Back when I was kid, I became friends with her after I moved to England. We grew up together. And for a time…”

Catra looked into Scorpia’s eyes and spoke with whatever confidence she could get a hold of.

“… She was my girlfriend.”

Scorpia blinked. She thought she heard Catra wrong at first.

“Surprised?” Catra smirked.

“I…” Scorpia cleared her throat. “That’s great, captain! I have to admit, not the person I was expecting, but now that makes sense! You both love adventure, and oceans, and boats…”

“You don’t mind that I’m attracted to women and not men?” Catra asked, almost expecting a bigger deal of that.

“Not at all! I’m more surprised that *she* was your partner. But I think it’s great that you know who you love,” Scorpia smiled. “Plus…”

Scorpia grinned, speaking in a low, almost whispering tone. “It’s not like you’d be the only one.”

Catra sat straight up. “Really?”

Scorpia nodded. “I didn’t think it was important to tell, but I’m the same as you! I only found out recently because *everyone* kept asking ‘when are you going to get a husband?’ and I was just like, ‘oh, do I have to?’. The idea of having a husband just… never stuck with me. But a wife? Oh, I would *love* a wife! The idea of saying ‘hey, this is my wife’ is just… Ah, I love it!”

“Well, it’s nice to know I’m not the only one on this ship who’s like that,” Catra smiled. “Makes me feel a little less alone. I appreciate you telling me, Scorpia.”

“Of course!” Scorpia beamed, before clicking her fingers at Catra. “Hey, look at that! Got you smiling!”

“You’re such an idiot…” Catra scoffed, shaking her head, and yet the smile remained.

Scorpia let out a deep, satisfied sigh through her nose. “It’s good to see you smile, captain. You’ve been so… not-smiling the last week.”

"Yes, well…" Catra looked down at her hands, interlocking her fingers with each other. "Don't think you noticed, but I said Adora was my girlfriend. Was."

"Oh? … Oh."

"It's been about… eight years," Catra said. "We broke up in 1902. Haven't seen each other since. So when I found out she'd be in Antarctica…"

"Ohh… I can see why things have been hard then," Scorpia replied. She scratched the back of her head. "Shoot. I… I'm not sure how to respond to that, captain."

"It's okay," Catra said. "You don't have to say anything. You were right, actually. Just getting it off my chest helped a lot."

"Well, I'm always here for you. You're allowed to feel… whatever it is you're feeling."

With those words, Scorpia reached out a hand and placed it on Catra's shoulder, giving it a firm squeeze as she smiled at her captain.

Catra stiffened up slightly at the touch. Scorpia's hand felt strong, and her gentle tone was like a comforting hug to her ears.

The comforting hand on her shoulder reminded Catra of Adora. And that both soothed her and terrified her.

"Oh, sorry!" Scorpia immediately took her hand away from Catra's shoulder. "It was instinct, I… Sorry, captain. I totally forgot that thing you have about personal space."

"It's fine," Catra reassured her. "If it's okay with you, I'm just going to stay down here for a while. Think things through. You should go check on the rest of the crew."

"You going to be okay?" Scorpia asked, trying to look into Catra's eyes, which had been downcast almost this entire time.

Catra nodded. “I will be.”

Scorpia had to take that response for what it was. There wasn’t much more Catra could say. She became someone of very few words when this kind of mood struck her.

She stood up from the box, heading for the stairs to go up to the deck. She was happy to have this conversation. Getting to know Catra personally was almost a rarity.

But that shoulder touch… It sent tingles down Scorpia’s spine. And she knew exactly why.

But she had to push those feelings down. Just like she practised every morning. Feeling that way about the captain…

No. She couldn’t. She just couldn’t.

Scorpia took another step up the stairs. Before she ascended, however, she stopped herself. There was one last thing she needed to do.

“1902. The year you and Adora broke up,” Scorpia started. “That’s when you joined the same crew I was on, wasn’t it?”

“Yes,” Catra nodded. “You… You helped me a lot through a tough time. I don’t think I ever thanked you for it.”

“You’ve thanked us enough by being the best captain ever,” Scorpia smiled. “But… I have to ask. I didn’t have anything to do with your break-up… did I?”

Silence came from Catra for a few seconds, before she eventually shook her head. “No.”

“Oh good! I was worried!” Scorpia let out a relieved chuckle.

She quickly silenced herself when she realised the bad timing.

Scorpia tapped her knuckles together, a tic she always had as she worked up the courage to ask the next question.

"Can I… ask what happened to cause the break-up?"

Catra looked to the floor, avoiding eye contact. She tried not to dwell on what happened that day for a reason. It only hurt to think about, and being asked about it was even worse.

Scorpia likely didn't know she was pushing boundaries she had no right to. Catra wasn't in the mood to tell her off.

So, Catra sighed, and gave a small response.

"It's complicated."

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*November 29, 1910.*

Adora ran the brush through the mane of her favourite pony, Swift Wind.

It wasn't really fair to have favourites, she'd been told. And truthfully, she did love all her ponies. But Swift Wind was the one she'd grown attached to the most, and the one who'd been easiest to train for this journey.

The brush separated the clumps in the mane, smoothing out the hair and giving Swift Wind a bit more comfort.

Adora could be a bit rough with her brushing, and she made sure to rub her hand along his neck as she cleaned him up a bit.

The month in New Zealand was meant to consist of preparation *and* rest, but it had simply ended up being mostly the former.

She'd been planning for what dangers they could encounter, the supplies they needed to leave at each depot before Winter hit, and what would be the best days to leave and return by. Despite

Bow and Glimmer's insistence to rest, Adora could only do anything but.

Resting usually led to thinking. And thinking usually led to dwelling on Catra.

She was going to be in Antarctica. Adora could still barely believe it. In fact, she had almost managed to gaslight herself into believing Catra would never be at Antarctica, and that some sick, twisted joke was being played on her.

But that letter was the truth. Those words were sent by Catra.

She pushed the thought down.

Adora ran her fingers through Swift Wind's mane one last time, before giving him a few complimentary pets. "Thatta boy."

"Captain!" A voice called out from the deck. It was Glimmer's.

"How are we going with preparations?" Adora called back, looking over to see Glimmer peeking her head down into the cargo hold.

"All set to sail, captain!" Glimmer grinned. "But, uh… You might want to see what's up here."

Adora narrowed her eyebrows, placing the brush away and heading towards the stairs, making her way up to see what issue had arisen. They were set to leave the dock soon, and after a month of maintenance, Terra Nova should've been in perfect shape. What would require her attention so urgently?

As she ascended up to the deck, she held up a hand to block the sun shining in her eyes. She squinted, looking around for whatever Glimmer was talking about.

But then she found it.

Terra Nova was fine. The deck was fine. Nothing on the boat required Adora's attention. Instead, it was the dock.

Namely, the people by the dock who had formed into a crowd to all cheer her on as she departed.

People in work clothes, men in suits, women in dresses, even young children sitting on the shoulders of their fathers were gathered by the dock, all to bid Terra Nova a farewell.

"Our race with Fram to the South Pole got some attention in the papers," Glimmer pointed out. "It's a matter of national pride back home. And these people are here to cheer you on in that race."

Adora looked out to the crowd, still trying to process just how big it was. It had to be in the hundreds, and their cheers were loud and filled with pride and hope. Each and every one of them saw Adora as a legend. A hero.

She couldn't help but let it get to her as she smiled. It wasn't about being a national hero, that didn't matter to her.

What mattered is that people were finally believing in her.

Instead of doubt or second guessing, these people *wanted* her to realise her goal.

"Anchors are raised and we've out our path set out, sir," Bow said as he approached Adora. "We're ready to depart on your command."

Adora heard Bow's affirmations. She heard the callouts between her crew, all prepping to leave. She heard the cheers of the crowd before her.

This was it. After fifteen years, this was it.

She walked along the port up to the front of the ship, heart filled with joy as she stepped up to a higher ground on the ship. The endless ocean before her, almost laying out a path that led south.

She only had one last thing to do. After all the preparation, the sacrifices, the pain, the blood and sweat and tears that went into

getting here, Adora only had to take one last step to commence the journey she'd dreamt of ever since she was thirteen.

Adora took a breath, and spoke the words.

"Set sail for Antarctica!"

Her words echoed out across the horizon, and the cheers were her response.

The crew responded with a synchronised 'aye-aye', and in just a few seconds, Terra Nova was pushing forward against the sea. Adora watched as the crew around her moved rapidly between stations, getting the ship going.

She looked to her left to see the crowd waving their hands, some even waving with their hats, as Terra Nova set forward, making its way south and away from the dock.

Among the crowd, Adora could see the children with stars in their eyes. In a way, she saw herself in those kids. That dream to make it to Antarctica. To be a legend like Mara.

Adora felt pride, joy, passion, hope.

But deep within, she felt fear. It was well hidden, but it was always there.

She looked south and made her way towards Antarctica. Towards Aurora Australis. Towards the unconquered South Pole.

And towards Catra.

# Promise Part 3

Chapter Summary

> A memory of a first drive, and a fleeting promise. In the present day, Catra has a heart-to-heart with Entrapta, and Adora endures harsh conditions.

*December 5, 1900.*

No matter how exciting an expedition was, there was no better feeling than being back on land after months at sea.

Catra left behind the ship she'd been on for over four months, having sailed most of the Arctic Ocean in search of wildlife. It was research for most of the crew, but for her, it was experience as a first mate for the very first time.

At eighteen years old, Catra was already handling work meant for people twice her age, and she was doing it twice as good. Her captain noted her performance many times, especially during crucial moments such as adjusting the sails against heavy winds.

She'd likely be recommended for future trips, or to other crews of higher status. Perhaps she'd be the captain of her own ship one day. It was a nice thought.

But for now, there was something even better than any expedition.

Scanning the crowd on the docks that awaited the arriving crew, and seeing Adora's smiling face among them.

Seeing those blue eyes for the first time in months was like being able to rest in the soft bed after a long day. Comforting, safe, warm.

Adora was Catra's home.

“Catra!” Adora beamed when she saw her girlfriend.

Adora quickly broke through the crowd, throwing her arms around Catra as soon as the first mate’s feet was off the wooden bridge and back on land.

She gripped the back of Catra’s shirt tight, burying her face in the crook of her neck and laying a gentle kiss upon her warm shoulder, breathing her in for the first time in months.

“Hey Adora,” Catra whispered, wrapping one arm around her girlfriend and returning the hug.

“Let me look at you,” Adora said as she separated, putting a hand on Catra’s shoulder and looking her up and down. “God… You still look so beautiful.”

“I do now. I sure don’t look so beautiful when I’m scrubbing decks and swearing at the crew,” Catra chuckled.

Well, I’m sure you have a *reason* for swearing at them,” Adora replied, her smile never leaving.

“I have plenty. But most of the time, it’s just because I find it funny,” Catra smirked.

Adora took some of Catra’s bags, slinging them over her shoulder and carrying them. Catra noticed that Adora’s arms had grown bulkier since she left, no doubt as a result of her Navy training, and the way her biceps tensed as she carried the bags was something Catra took *particular* note of.

Staring for too long almost made Catra blush, and she was quick to look up at the sky as she walked.

The two women cleared themselves away from the crowd and into the nearby cluster of buildings, heading for the main road by going through quiet alleyways.

Catra waited until they were well out of sight, before she quickly leant over to place a kiss on Adora's cheek. "I've missed you."

"I have too," Adora smiled, returning with another kiss, but this time, a peck on the lips, followed by another. "God, I've missed you so fucking much."

Adora placed another few kisses on Catra's lips, a few in rapid succession and a few with gaps between. Catra returned each and every one, even giggling a bit when Adora kissed her neck.

"Alright, alright, save the rest for later," Catra smiled.

"You have a *lot* of kisses to make up for," Adora said, and Catra was more than happy to do exactly that when they got home.

Catra was still getting used to being on land, with no more rocking beneath her feet. Her body felt weightless, and she was still adjusting to not having to balance herself anymore. It'd take a few days to get back into the norm of things.

"So…" Catra spoke up. "What have you been up to while I was gone?"

"Well, I turned in my handwritten test for the Navy just last week. If the results are good, I'll be up for enlisting and basic training," Adora replied, though she didn't seem too proud of it.

"Are the tests hard?" Catra asked.

"Yes, but I've studied well enough. My dad won't let me do anything less than my absolute best," Adora sighed. She gave a weak smile. "Don't suppose I can come on your next expedition?"

"I'm really trying to advocate for you, Adora, but…" Catra sighed. "It's difficult. I was *extremely* lucky to be accepted onto a ship a couple of years ago to prove myself, but that's rare. You don't really have any official experience yet, and they're only looking for the best. I told them you already knew everything, but…"

"It's fine, Catra. I understand why they're not accepting me," Adora replied, trying to comfort her girlfriend. "Besides, even if I somehow got accepted on one of your expeditions, my dad would be quick to put a stop to it. 'My girl only travels on Navy boats, not pieces of junk', or something along those lines."

"And yet you still won't let me punch him."

"I'll let you do it one day," Adora chuckled.

Hearing the chatter up ahead, the two of them quickly looked up and stepped a few inches away from each other as they emerged from the alleyway onto the main road.

Catra had almost forgotten what the streets of England were like. Cobblestone roads cluttered with carriages led by horses, and pedestrians who wore various suits and dresses of the black and white variety.

In her greasy ship clothes, Catra stuck out amongst the other women in elegant dresses and fluffy skirts.

"Home, sweet home," Catra mumbled as she walked with Adora through the streets, attracting the occasional glance from a passer-by who couldn't comprehend Catra looking so *dirty.*

"Did you miss it?" Adora almost jokingly asked.

"Absolutely not."

Catra couldn't help but notice something that had changed in her few months away: how frequently cars were driving on the road. What was a rarity a couple of years ago had turned into something more common among high society, with families taking leisurely drives around town.

Granted, the number of cars was still relatively low compared to other vehicles, but to see something not led by a horse still boggled Catra's mind.

Soon enough, she watched as Adora approached one of those cars parked near the sidewalk.

At first, she thought they were simply going to cross the street, maybe stop at a hotel.

But then, Adora opened the passenger side door of the car, and smiled at her partner. “Feel like going for a drive?”

Catra’s jaw almost hit the floor.

“You *have* one of those?!” She gawked at the car.

“My dad got it as a gift from one of his old generals,” Adora replied. “But it’s gone to waste. He just uses it to show off to everyone. I think it’s much more suited to treating my girlfriend properly.”

Catra looked at the car up and down. It was small, painted black and could barely fit two people. The seat was made of leather and there was no roof to be found like a usual carriage. There was no storage space too, so they’d have to carry their bags on their laps while they drove.

But Catra did not mind one bit.

“I can’t believe I can actually do this…” She chuckled, stepping up into the car and taking a seat on the left side, adjusting herself against the material.

Adora laughed at Catra’s reaction as she walked around, taking her seat on the right side of the car.

Adora placed one hand on the lever to her right and another hand on the tiller to steer. She pushed the lever forward until it clicked, and the car slowly began to move.

She moved the tiller towards Catra to steer the car right, merging onto the road and into relatively light traffic. Speed definitely

wasn't an advantage, the car going at a slow pace as it cruised down the street.

Catra could care less about speed. She was in a fucking *car*.

"I think I've gotten the hang of driving this, too!" Adora grinned as she pushed the lever forward until it clicked once more.

The lever had three settings for the car's speed: slow-forward, fast-forward or reverse. Even at fast forward, it was only going slightly faster than most horse-led carriages.

"Adora, I swear I would marry you if I could!" Catra laughed as she took in the feeling of being in the car, the wind on her face and the sound of the wheels crackling against the cobblestone street below. "When'd you learn how to drive?"

"My dad felt nice enough to have me drive home after I handed in my Navy test," Adora replied. "Reckons I could use the experience of being in command of a vehicle."

"So you've got your way into the Navy and you've got a car!" Catra grinned as she looked around, noting all the pedestrians stopping to look at the car. "I don't suppose among all that, *you* found a way for us to get onto a ship to Antarctica together?"

It was mostly jest, but there was a hint of seriousness in her words.

Adora's face hardened at the question, her lips thinning as she looked out to the left side, facing away from Catra.

"It's… It's just difficult," Adora replied, raising her voice a bit to be heard over the engine. "I can't simply take a civilian onto a Navy ship just because we have a childhood dream."

Catra frowned. "I wouldn't call myself a *civilian*."

"You know what I mean. Besides, even after I do get into the Navy, I don't think I'll be travelling to the South Pole for a while."

Catra looked to her driver. “Why not?”

“There’s a lot I have to do before I’m sent on anything major,” Adora explained. “I have to pass training and spend a few years out at sea. I have to go through the ranks. It might take a while before I can even become captain. I can’t just luck out like you did.”

“I didn’t *luck out*,” Catra defended herself. “I just got noticed one day, but I worked my ass off after that!”

“Sorry. Bad wording,” Adora corrected herself. “Look, all I’m saying is, these things take time. Don’t go expecting my first trip to suddenly be the one that takes us to the South Pole.”

“I’m not an *idiot*, Adora, I know that things take time. I was just asking if you’d found any potential options yet,” Catra asserted. “God, you make it sound like you don’t even *want* to go to Antarctica.”

“Of course I do! It’s just…” Adora sighed. “It’s difficult, okay? We’re both from separate nations. I’m in the military and you’re on expeditions for wildlife. It’s difficult enough to even get your hands on a ship, and we’d need to be *highly* trained and experienced to even attempt a polar trip, and-“

“You still have the ring, don’t you?” Catra cut her off.

Adora glanced over to her partner to see her face. She was frowning, her narrowed eyes almost expressing disappointment in Adora.

It hurt to see.

Adora reached for her collarbone, going under her shirt to pull out the ring, which she wore like a necklace with the chain linked through it. “Of course I do.”

“Then as long as you have that, we *have* to find a way to get there together, no matter how hard it may seem!” Catra spoke

sternly. “We can’t just give up. This is what we dreamed of for years.”

“Yes, but…”

“You *promised*, Adora.”

Adora looked to her partner. Her intense gaze. She felt like Catra’s determination was almost smothering her. This childhood dream meant everything to her.

Adora was starting to wonder if this was all worth it.

She loved Catra, but even bringing up slight concern about their trip garnered frowns and frustration from Catra. It was like Catra didn’t want to hear anything other than good news and affirmations.

So, just like always, Adora kept her thoughts to herself.

Catra’s happiness was all that mattered. Adora needed to remind herself of that. Even if it hurt sometimes.

So, without voicing another concern, Adora nodded. “I know. We’ll figure it out.”

“That’s what I like to hear,” Catra grinned. “I love you, Adora. We’ll make it together.”

Adora loved seeing that grin, she truly did. She wanted nothing more than to go to Antarctica with the love of her life. That wish never left.

But that wish was also slowly being crushed under the weight of reality.

Each passing day was making Adora realise more and more that the dream of seeing Aurora Australis together with Catra was just becoming too difficult. Perhaps one of them could see it, yes, but

together? Two women from separate nations with separate ways of travel and separate families?

Adora's doubts were clouding her mind. And clouding her love.

She couldn't even get a word out. She was alone in her doubt. She was afraid of upsetting Catra, of ruining everything they'd dreamt about. She just had to push, even when it involved getting herself hurt.

It was going to be worth it in the end. It had to be.

For all the time Adora spent doubting, she never came to realise one thing on that drive. One thing that her partner very much took notice of.

Adora never said 'I love you' back to Catra.

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*December 5, 1910.*

Even after spending so long at sea, Catra could never get enough of seeing the blue ocean.

The stillness of the water at points was almost hypnotising. The way it extended on forever was mesmerising. And on occasion, some sort of sea creature would jump out to quickly say hello.

She gripped onto the mast, having climbed to the highest point of Fram to look at the water ahead. The sun shined upon her, but the temperature didn't reflect it. As they headed further south, it was getting colder and colder by the second.

But even among all the chaos, up here, Catra had peace. Climbing the mast was one of her favourite things to do.

The sound of the wind. The view of the endless blue. The scent of salt clashing with the sweetness of the breeze. Catra loved it all.

There was also the fact that when she looked to her right, she saw that Entrapta was right up here with her.

“Hi, captain!”

“JESUS, FUCK!” Catra involuntarily cried, almost losing grip on the mast. “When did you get up here?!”

“About four minutes ago!” Entrapta responded with that big smile. “You looked so peaceful and I didn’t want to scare you, so I was waiting until you noticed me.”

“Entrapta…”

“And now you have!”

Catra had about a thousand words to say and no idea what order to put them in.

Instead, she just sighed, turning her body to face her second mate whilst clinging onto the mast. “We’ll… talk about all that later. What did you come up here for?”

“Just a report!” Entrapta responded. “Terra Nova departed from New Zealand a few days ago and is headed towards Antarctica. They’ll be ahead of us.”

“Right…” Catra muttered under her breath. “Well, it’s no matter. Regardless of who arrives first, no one is leaving base camp until the Antarctic Winter is over. Is that all?”

“That’s all!” Entrapta said.

Catra blinked. “You climbed up here just to tell me that?”

“I did!”

Entrapta was one of the few people who could render Catra speechless on an almost daily basis.

“Well, if you’re already up here, might as well stick around,” Catra sighed, turning to face the ocean once more. “You spend all that time cooped up in that lab of yours, you’ll miss all the sights.”

“Not to worry, captain!” Entrapta raised a finger. “My lab can be taken anywhere. I’ll be on the field once we arrive in Antarctica, and I’ll be sure to find any nearby penguin colonies!”

“… And you’ll come to the South Pole with me too, right?” Catra asked.

“Oh, sure, that too. But the penguin colonies along the way will be fascinating!” Entrapta gushed.

“You sure love penguins, don’t you?” Catra raised an eyebrow.

“I always have,” Entrapta nodded. “They were the first animal species I ever researched when I was younger, but I’ve never seen one in person before. Being able to get some hands-on experience…”

“I’m sure we’ll find some penguins in Antarctica,” Catra said. “I just hope they don’t go pecking my eyes out.”

“Just avoid the chinstrap penguins in that case,” Entrapta pointed out. “They’re the angry ones. The rest don’t really get that mad unless you go near their eggs.”

“I’ll keep that in mind.”

A comfortable silence followed between the two of them. Catra kept her eyes peered on the ocean, looking at the gentle waves and almost glassy surface which reflected the bright sun.

She loved the way Fram was able to withstand the occasional bump, only jostling around a bit but pushing forward nonetheless. She was proud of her ship.

“Catra, can I ask something?” Entrapta spoke up after a few seconds of silence, her eyes still directed to the water.

“Yes?” Catra looked to her second mate.

“Why haven’t you told me to go away yet?”

The bluntness of Entrapta’s statement certainly came out of nowhere.

Catra raised both her eyebrows. “Why the hell would I say that?”

“Every other captain I served under always told me to do that after some time,” Entrapta plainly stated like it was a basic fact, looking to Catra with an expressionless face. “I was useful to them, but they never wanted to… well, ‘listen to my ramblings’. They just stuck me in a lab until they could find another researcher to replace me with. One that talked less.”

“That…” Catra shook her head. “A captain shouldn’t do that to any crewmate.”

“Every other captain I’ve served with has,” Entrapta said. “That’s why I like to stay in the lab. At least in there, I won’t be bothering anyone.”

“You don’t bother me,” Catra replied. “And you don’t bother anyone on the crew either. They love when you join us at supper. Your passion just spreads like a fire when you start talking about your work. I think half the crew can name every penguin species in Antarctica by now.”

“Are you… sure I don’t bother you?” Entrapta asked, hiding her face from Catra by looking at the opposite direction.

“I’m sure,” Catra spoke. “You’re a valuable crewmate. Having you on Fram the last couple of years has really made a remarkable difference in how we run things, and all of it for the better.”

“Really…?” Entrapta asked.

“Really,” Catra nodded. “I feel *much* safer with you on board. You have a good grasp on how to handle the ship’s finer mechanics,

and your daily reports have genuinely been helpful. Plus, I've never seen a researcher who's valuable both in a lab and on the field. You're unique, Entrapta. The way you do things is different. But that doesn't mean it's wrong."

Entrapta had never heard those words in her life. She wasn't quite sure how to take them. For the first time, it was Catra who had rendered her speechless.

Entrapta wasn't 'normal'. She knew that much herself from when she was younger. The way she did things was unconventional, and she struggled to maintain friends, no matter how hard she tried.

She was always wondering when her next screw-up would be.

Catra was the first captain who hadn't screamed at her yet. The first captain who hadn't kicked her off for being bothersome. The first captain to appreciate and encourage her passion, instead of questioning her sanity.

Entrapta was thankful for that, but she still never felt confident in her social skills.

Despite being told she was a 'value' to the crew, she still didn't know if anyone considered her a friend. She was afraid to ask.

Interaction scared her, and yet she craved connection.

An endless contradiction.

"… Holy shit."

Entrapta heard Catra observe something, and she looked up. She only just realised she'd been hiding her face for the last few minutes.

She looked to where Catra was looking, and soon noticed what she noticed. "Oh… Oh, wow…"

The two of them saw, in the far-off distance, a patch of sky that was filled with gray clouds and crackling lightning. It didn't take long for them to realise what was off in the distance.

Fram had just narrowly avoided a storm.

"Will that hit us?" Catra asked her second mate.

"If we keep on our current course, we should be able to steer clear of it," Entrapta replied. "Probably."

Catra could only hope that Entrapta was right. That storm looked bad. And although she was in a race…

She hoped that Terra Nova would be able to avoid that storm too.

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Adora had been rudely awoken many times in her life.

During basic training, it was common to have ice cold water dumped on her bed at first sunlight, or to have the sheets ripped out from atop her. She was almost used to rude awakenings.

She certainly wasn't used to being awoken by her ship rocking around so hard that it threw her out of her bed and slammed her against the wall.

That was the rudest awakening yet.

She felt the wind drain from her lungs as she smashed against the metal wall, quickly collapsing to the ground on her front and gripping the side of her body that had been hurt by the sudden impact.

What the hell was causing Terra Nova to sway around so violently?

Once all of her senses had come back to her, she soon was able to process the sounds of heavy wind and rain smashing against the boat. It didn't take long for her to realise what had happened.

A storm had hit the ship.

She took in a deep breath once she was able to breathe, and muttered only one word.

“Fuck.”

Adora quickly stood up, pushing through the pain and putting on some long pants, leaving herself in the sleeveless shirt as she opened the door and stepped out onto the deck.

It was nearly one in the morning and the sky was still dark. No doubt the storm had somehow crept up on them through the night sky. She felt the heavy rain against her bare arms as she pushed up to the steering wheel, where one of her crewmates furiously tried to keep the boat balanced.

“Sorry, captain!” The steering crewmate immediately spoke up. “Tried to steer away but the fucker caught up with us!”

“Keep this ship up!” Adora commanded of her crewmate. “It hasn’t even been a week since we left and we’re already in a damn storm… What’s the damage?”

“Nothing on deck!” The crewmate responded. “But…”

“Adora!”

The captain quickly turned to the direction of Glimmer’s voice, seeing her sticking her head out from below the deck and in the cargo hold.

“What’s going on over here?!” Adora called out to her first mate.

“We’re being flooded!”

Adora’s eyes widened, and she quickly ran from the wheel towards the cargo hold. She made her way past Glimmer and down the stairs, expecting the water to only be about ankle-deep.

But it was to her horror that she realised the water had flooded so fast that it was nearly up to her waist.

The ponies were freaking out and the dogs were desperately trying to keep their heads above the water. Supplies and boxes floated on the floodwater, all of it barely visible in the pitch-black cargo hold.

"Are you two okay?" Adora heard Bow's voice come from behind as he approached Adora and Glimmer.

"This ship is going to go down if we don't do something," Adora spoke to herself, before quickly ascending up the ladder and onto the deck. "Bow, get a small team and tell them to get everything out of the cargo hold and on the deck! We need to save every supply and animal we can!"

"Aye-aye!" Bow replied, rushing off to the rest of the crew.

"Glimmer, you get the rest of the crew and every bucket you can find. If the cargo hold is flooded, then the engine room will be too. We need to clear out as much water as we can," Adora commanded her first mate.

"Be careful, captain!" Glimmer called out as she went to round up the rest of the crew.

With Bow and Glimmer managing everyone else, Adora quickly made her way towards the engine room. The rain was dampening her long hair and freezing her body as her wet clothes stuck to her, but she couldn't care less.

Terra Nova was *not* going down. Not this early.

She opened the trapdoor into the engine room, and just as predicted, water had flooded into here too. She could barely see anything apart from the reflection of the water.

The boat rocked against the heavy waves, Adora nearly losing her balance against the slippery deck. She had to hope no one was

being thrown overboard by these waves.

Within the engine room were a series of pipes that were meant to pump out any water that seeped into the ship. If there was a flood, it means those pipes had to be malfunctioning.

Finding her way to the pipes in the dark, flooded engine room would be impossible for anyone.

But Adora knew this ship like the back of her hand.

She descended into the engine room, feeling the water come up to her waist. It was freezing, but she pushed through. The adrenaline was keeping her going for now.

Adora took a deep breath, before she quickly submerged herself into the freezing water.

Everything was dark, and with the waves furiously beating at Terra Nova, there was a particular danger of the ship smashing Adora against the hard pipes.

It would be especially bad if she hit those pipes headfirst.

Adora felt her way around the engine room, running her hands along the steel walls and being sure to keep her head tucked in. She was practically blind, relying on her sense of touch to get around.

Eventually, she found her way to the pumps. Reaching in, it didn't take long for her to figure out the problem.

A gummy, paste-like wall consisting likely of coal, oil and dirt mixing with the water had clogged the pumps.

That paste-like wall could be broken, but not with the current flood. They'd have to clear this water out, bucket by bucket.

Adora backed away from the pipes and stood up, the water still waist high. She took a deep breath once she emerged, spitting

out the salty ocean water out.

To her relief, she could already hear the rain outside slowly settling. The waves were still angry, but relaxing minute by minute.

“Captain, are you down here?!” Glimmer’s voice called out into the engine room.

“I am!” Adora called back, looking up to see Glimmer carrying a lamp which illuminated her face well enough. “Did you bring the crew?”

“And every damn bucket I could find!” Glimmer grinned. “We’re steering away from the storm as best we can. Should be in the clear soon enough.”

“And we’ve already got most of the supplies on deck!” Bow’s voice called out as he approached the engine room.

“Good work, you two,” Adora said as she made her way through the flooded engine room towards the ladder. “Pass those buckets down here. We’ll need to work fast.”

“Are we going to be alright, captain?” Bow asked as Glimmer descended down into the engine room.

“If we work fast and hard, we can keep the damage to a minimum,” Adora nodded, reaching out for a bucket. “Everyone just-”

Adora was cut off as the ship was suddenly slammed by a wave, almost toppling it to the side.

Adora managed to find a wall to grip onto and most of the crew managed to keep their balance. Most of them.

Except Glimmer.

It was only a few seconds after that everyone realised Glimmer had fallen off the ladder and into the waist-deep water of the engine room. Only her lamp was left behind, floating on the surface.

Glimmer had fallen into shallow water, in a room filled with hard metal objects, and likely headfirst…

"Glimmer!" Adora cried out, going to dive under once more.

But before anyone could do anything, one person had the reaction time and instinct to immediately jump into the water, ignoring their own safety.

That person was none other than Bow.

Adora could only watch as Bow dived under the water, disappearing for a few seconds into the shallow engine room water. Adora had to stay back, not wanting to smother either of them, but desperately hoping they both make it up.

Glimmer falling could spell disaster. She could've knocked her head on something, or the sudden shock of the freezing water could've made her temporarily forget how to swim. Adora had seen it happen before.

She was almost prepared to go in after them. They weren't just her first and second mates. They were her friends.

She couldn't lose someone close to her again.

But finally, she saw two figures emerge from the water.

Bow had managed to drag Glimmer to the surface, both of them coughing up the salty ocean water.

"Oh, thank god…" Adora sighed with relief as she heard them gasping for air.

“I’m fine!” Glimmer immediately called out between coughs. “Just scared the crap out of me!”

“Are you sure?!” Bow asked, his arm still wrapped around Glimmer’s back as he looked down at her.

“I’m sure,” Glimmer nodded, putting a hand over Bow’s and gripping it tight. “You didn’t need to jump after me. You could’ve gotten yourself hurt, Bow…”

“I saw you go under and I just…” Bow shook his head. “I thought I lost you.”

“I’m not dying just yet,” Glimmer chuckled.

Adora was happy enough to see her first and second mate assisting each other. Glimmer seemed relatively fine, though the freezing water was giving her shivers now.

As they recovered, the rest of the crew had formed some assembly lines, ready to pass buckets along and toss them into the ocean. “Ready to help, captain!”

“Glimmer, you still okay to assist?” Adora asked her first mate.

“As always, captain,” Glimmer grinned, handing Adora the first bucket to use.

“Wait, Glimmer…” Bow put a hand on his friend’s shoulder.

“I’ll be fine,” Glimmer reassured him. “I promise.”

Bow looked to Glimmer for a few more seconds, seeing her smile and her confidence. He sighed. “Just… be careful. Okay?”

“I should be the one telling you that,” Glimmer scoffed, before pushing a bucket against his chest. “Now come on. This flood isn’t getting any lower.”

Bow took the bucket in his hand, smiling at his friend for a few more seconds, before turning to scoop the water into the bucket, handing it up to the crew to dump out.

And so begun the process of clearing the floodwater out of Terra Nova. Buckets being passed back and forth between the crew, returning the ocean to where it belonged.

Adora knew they were in for a long haul, but at the very least, the ship wouldn't sink within the first week of leaving New Zealand. *That* wouldn't be good news to return home with.

As she worked tirelessly, Adora couldn't help but think of one thing: Glimmer and Bow's closeness.

Bow didn't hesitate for a second to jump in after Glimmer when she fell. They reassured each other, and even now, they held onto each other when the ship began to rock.

They had each other's backs, no matter what.

It was a sweet sight.

And yet, Adora knew that if she were into fall under the water, there would be only one person who'd jump after her without a hint of hesitation. One person who'd pick her up if she fell down.

But she'd lost that person eight years ago.

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*December 8, 1901.*

Nineteen-year-old Adora was getting less sleep these days.

She laid in her soft bed, and yet her eyes were wide open, looking at the droplets upon the window next to her. She could hear the rolling of carriage wheels against the road outside, and the gentle rain pattering against the roof.

She felt warm. The sheets covering her, the bed engulfing her, and Catra beside her, holding her close as she slept.

Adora was still trying to get used to staying at a new place, and Catra was helping her through the more lonely nights. It wasn't something she could do often, but every time Adora slept with Catra's arms around her, she felt a little more comfortable.

But it was a fleeting comfort.

Adora sighed, rolling onto her back and sitting up. She'd been trying to sleep, but it wasn't coming. She was simply closing her eyes, but she knew it was pointless.

It was one of those nights.

She ran her hands down her face, before bringing it up and raking her fingers through her hair.

She still wore the promise ring. The necklace linked around her neck, and the ring laid against her bare chest. It was cold.

That promise ring weighed heavier each and every day.

"Mmph…" Catra tensed in her sleep, frowning as her eyes slowly fluttered open, before she looked up to her girlfriend. "Adora…?"

"Sorry. I didn't mean to wake you," Adora apologised, her eyes still looking to the window.

"S'okay," Catra yawned, rubbing her eyes with her thumb and index finger as she sat up, putting a hand on Adora's bare back. "You feeling alright?"

No.

No, Adora was *not* feeling alright.

She wanted to tell Catra that this promise was weighing on her shoulders and slowly crushing her.

She wanted to tell Catra that everything she's been doing for this promise is making her more and more miserable.

She wanted to tell Catra that the reason she can't sleep is because she has nightmares about upsetting her. About losing her. About losing everything she's worked so hard to gain.

She wanted to tell Catra the truth.

But she couldn't.

"Just…" Adora sighed. "Worried about basic training."

Catra's nails gently raked against Adora's back, sending tingles up her spine as she rested her chin on Adora's shoulder.

"That's not for another few months, silly," Catra smiled. "You don't have to worry so much."

"I know. But…" Adora brought her knees up to her chest. "I'm afraid of failing. I'm afraid of letting you down. I'm afraid of… ruining everything."

Catra stilled her gentle scratching.

"Adora…" Catra whispered, putting a hand on her girlfriend's cheek and turning her to look into her eyes. "You shouldn't have to be afraid of that. You won't let me down, no matter what."

"Really…?" Adora asked, her eyebrows raising.

"Yes," Catra smiled. "Because I *know* you. I know you'll find a way for us. I know you'll keep your promise, no matter what."

Adora's heart dropped.

But she hid her agony with a smile.

"I will…" Adora replied. She put her hand over Catra's.

“And even if you go down,” Catra started. “Even if, somehow, you end up tripping and falling…”

She squeezed Adora’s hand and grinned. “I’ll be right here to pick you up, Adora. I promise.”

Another promise.

Adora felt Catra’s hand squeeze around her. She looked into her heterochromatic eyes. She saw the genuine love within them. It was a look Adora could never get enough of.

“God…” Adora sighed, pushing her forehead against Catra’s. “I love you so fucking much…”

“I love you too,” Catra replied, her voice soft, like a gentle vibration against Adora’s ear.

Catra raised a hand, pressing it firm against the ring resting on Adora’s chest, gripping it tight. “As long as we have this…” Catra whispered.

“I know,” Adora replied.

They stayed there like that. Foreheads touching, rain patting against the window, sheets bunched at their waists. Adora could feel Catra’s warm breath against her mouth, and the hand pressed firm against her chest, gripping the promise ring.

She loved Catra so much.

And she didn’t want to lose her.

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*December 15, 1910.*

Catra held the silver ring in the palm of her hand.

She leaned over the starboard ledge as Fram sailed through the night. The deck was quiet and most of the crew were resting from

a long day of work.

Catra couldn't sleep. She likely wasn't going to sleep tonight.

After all, it was December 15th.

The day she and Adora separated eight years ago.

This date always hurt Catra. The memories of their last words rung in her ears. All of that happiness, all of that joy, all overshadowed by the events of a few minutes.

Every time this date rolled around, there was that same temptation.

The temptation to get rid of the ring, and the memories of Adora, forever.

Catra had never quite moved on. She'd never been with anyone else in the last eight years. She was too afraid to form that sort of connection again, only to lose it once more.

So instead, she kept everyone at arm's length. Spared herself the pain.

She tried her hardest to get the memories of Adora out of her head, but it never happened.

There was never a sense of closure between them.

But today… today would be different.

Catra gripped the ring in her hand and stood up. The water was before her. The endless ocean was the greatest place to hide anything. There was no chance of changing her mind once it was done.

She reeled back a hand.

One throw. One throw and the ring would be gone. She'd finally be able to move on. She'd finally be able to push forward. To come out of Adora's shadow.

She closed her eyes. It was just one movement. It was just a stupid ring. It was just stupid memories. She could get rid of it all so easily.

… And yet she couldn't do it.

It was the same every time. She just couldn't do it.

Catra sighed, dropping her hand and gripping the ring tight. It wasn't going anywhere anytime soon.

Even after eight years, Adora still had a grip on her.

"Damn you, Adora…"

Catra pocketed the ring once more, readying herself to go to her quarters and shut herself off from the world for a few hours.

But as she went to turn, she suddenly spotted something in the dark ocean.

It was barely visible. She only just saw the silhouette, and she was lucky to have caught it. It was small and isolated, and yet it was *vastly* important.

It was enough to bring a slight smile to the captain's face.

For the first time, Catra spotted ice in the ocean.

# Promise Part 4

Chapter Summary

Glimmer struggles with her feelings. Scorpia receives a surprise from Catra and some kind words from Entrapta. The ice is broken.

Chapter Notes

Sorry for the delay on this one! Life got much busier than I anticipated and I could barely find time to write. I have this chapter and the next one all written out and ready to post within the next few days!
You may have also noticed the total chapter count has gone up (again) because I had to split a chapter (again). I'm nothing if not consistent.
Hope y'all enjoy! Thanks for all the support <3

*December 10, 1910.*

The blue skies above Terra Nova were a most welcome sight among the crew.

It had taken a few days to fully clear out the flood water, clean the pipes and assess the damage left behind by the storm. Conditions still weren't perfect as the temperature dropped more and more the further south they travelled, but the crew worked hard.

Adora walked among her cargo which was still placed up on the deck after being moved out of the lower holds. The wooden boxes were fine, and the ponies seemed to have made it out okay.

Unfortunately, a major issue was the motorised sledges. Among all the flood water and heavy movement, they had broken; reduced down to normal, man-hauled sledges.

Those motorised sledges were the biggest advantage Adora had, both over Catra and just in general. And now it was gone.

But Adora kept a strong morale, putting on a brave smile and keeping confidence. Who *really* needs motorised sledges anyway? Plenty of people had conquered the polar regions without them.

Even if it was all just an act, Adora had to smile. As a captain, she *had* to.

Apart from that, there was another matter in particular Adora was concerned about. A matter so great that even *she* couldn't hide her worry from the crew.

"Sir."

Adora turned to see Glimmer approaching, a quick report in her hand. She'd been working tirelessly since the storm, but her demeanour showed no signs of exhaustion.

Glimmer handed the report to Adora. "All the dogs have been looked at."

Adora took the report as she looked to her first mate, her eyebrows narrowed. A small amount of worry, a small amount of vulnerability. "Is it bad news?"

"Thankfully, not as bad as it could've been," Glimmer sighed with some relief as Adora flipped through the pages of listed injuries and concerns. "There's a few minor injuries among the dogs, but nothing that can't be healed with rest and time."

Adora felt her shoulders loosen as she heard the news, untensing her jaw and nodding. "Thank you, Glimmer. That's probably the best case scenario we could've gotten out of that storm."

Even with the good news, Adora couldn't help but wonder about something else:

Did Catra have to endure that storm? Was she okay?

Adora found herself thinking more and more about Catra recently. She wasn't sure if that was a good thing or a bad thing.

"Trust me, I'm relieved too," Glimmer replied. "Bow's been on the verge of tears over those dogs. He visited them… probably more than anyone else. They all really love him."

Adora noticed Glimmer's voice trailing off as she spoke. She looked to see Glimmer's eyes were cast elsewhere. She followed her gaze to see what was so distracting.

Of course. Glimmer was looking at Bow.

The second mate was with the rest of the crew, delivering the good news about the dogs with beaming smile on his face. That smile cast upon everyone else's faces, like an infectious joy. Between the good news about the dogs and Bow's general demeanour of pure sunshine, it was hard *not* to smile.

The captain looked back down to Glimmer, noticing a soft admiration on her face along with a slight flush on her cheeks.

"I can't blame them. Bow's a loveable guy, huh?" Adora replied with an almost teasing tone as she handed back the report.

"He is…" Glimmer whispered to herself, taking the report back in her hands. She looked on to Bow for a second longer, before quickly snapping her head back to Adora. "Wait, was that comment directed at me?"

"Is there any other reports I should know of?" Adora ignored the question, her knowing smile never leaving as she inspected the horse's feeds.

"I… None, sir," Glimmer replied with a hint of hesitation.

A few seconds of silence. Adora could see that, other than the broken motorised sledges, none of the other equipment had suffered major damage. The trip to the South Pole would be a little tougher, but not impossible.

Glimmer, on the other hand, had other concerns.

"Captain…" Glimmer cleared her throat. "I promise there's nothing going on between the second mate and I."

"I see," Adora nodded, and yet that smirk wasn't going away. Glimmer was starting to become mildly irked by it.

"Listen, I'm aware that relationships between crew is often frowned upon, but…"

"It's frowned upon in the *official* rules," Adora interrupted. "But I don't give a *shit* about the official rules. Whatever you and Bow get up to, I fully support it. Plus, since when have *you* cared about the rules anyway?"

"I…"

With that, Adora picked up one of the wooden boxes on the deck, walking past Glimmer and towards the stairs. "If that's all, I'll be down in the cargo hold. We need to get all the gear back down there anyway."

Glimmer could only blink as Adora left her behind with that knowing smile.

The first mate was left standing by her lonesome, that flush still on her cheeks. The captain *clearly* wasn't as oblivious as Glimmer had assumed.

She looked to Bow once more. He was now talking with the crew from the lab, assessing their supplies and seeing if anything was lost in the storm. His face was one of concentration, understanding, and a soft smile every now and then.

He was beautiful in almost every sense of the word. Glimmer loved his smile, loved his concern for others, and *especially* loved hearing him talk about his passions endlessly. She also loved the way he…

Wait.

Glimmer soon realised she was standing around staring at one guy for *way* too long.

Fuck. She needed a distraction.

"H… Hold on!" Glimmer called out to Adora, grabbing the nearest box and lifting it, carrying it down to the cargo hold with her captain. "I'll help out."

"Sure. Extra set of hands never hurts," Adora replied with a strained voice as she stepped down the steep stairs to the mostly empty cargo hold.

Adora walked towards one of the more empty corners, placing the heavy box down with a grunt and patting her hands free of dirt and soreness. She heard Glimmer place her box in another corner.

The first mate, however, seemed distracted. She was simply performing the task with her body, but her mind was elsewhere.

"Glimmer," Adora called out, getting her attention. "Something you want to talk about?"

Her name being called out shot Glimmer back to reality. She blinked, looking to her captain. "Huh? Oh, uh… I'm fine, captain. Sir."

"You've known me for eight years," Adora chuckled, leaning against the box. "And yet you *still* insist on calling me 'captain'."

"Agh, I know. It's just… hard," Glimmer replied with an annoyed tone. "Training just drills the 'yes, captain' attitude into you."

"Whatever works best for you, I suppose," Adora said, though her tone sounded a bit… defeated. "But really. Is everything alright? You can always talk to me."

Glimmer crossed her arms, avoiding eye contact as she sighed. "Just… Just feelings."

"Such as…?"

"I don't know! Just…" Glimmer threw her hands up. "Fucking feelings!"

"And if we were to specify those feelings…?"

Adora already knew. She just needed Glimmer to say it. They both knew where this was going.

Glimmer sighed, burying her face in one hand and speaking with a mumble.

"The kind of feelings that have made me fall in love with my best friend, even though that's probably a terrible thing."

Adora raised an eyebrow. She was surprised by that last bit.

"Why's that a terrible thing? You and Bow make a great pair already."

"Exactly! So why change what's already perfect?" Glimmer asked. "He and I… We're meant to just be friends. Anything more and there's just… too many risks."

"How can you be sure of that?"

"I just… I just know, okay?!" Glimmer insisted with an annoyed tone.

"Well…" Adora scratched at her own chin. "How long have you felt *this* way about him?"

"Maybe a year. Maybe all my life," Glimmer scoffed, shaking her head. "I don't know at this point… He's always been there. He's picked me up when I fell down. He's held me when I cried. He's even promised to sing for me. He…"

“Wait, wait, wait…” Adora held up a hand. “He’s promised to *sing* for you?”

“Oh, that was *years* ago. He’s probably forgotten by now,” Glimmer shook her head.

“He promised. To sing for you. And you think he sees you as just a friend?”

“Adora, he’s friendly to *everyone* like that.”

“I don’t know about you, but I don’t promise people I’d sing for them unless I was feeling a certain way about them,” Adora said.

“Yes, but…” Glimmer sighed. “It’s not the same. You don’t understand.”

Adora sighed. “Maybe I don’t. But I can at least try, can’t I?” Adora asked. “You two talk about everything together. Why haven’t you told him any of this?”

“I don’t know. I’m… I’m just scared, Adora.”

“Of rejection?”

“Of losing *everything.* Bow means so much to me,” Glimmer’s eyes were downcast. “And I figure, as long as I don’t tell him these stupid things, everything will be fine. If I ignore these feelings, they’ll just go away.”

“That’s no way to live, Glimmer,” Adora spoke gently. “You can’t just hide your love. It’ll eat away at you.”

“But what if it all goes wrong?” Glimmer took a sharp breath. “What if I confess to him and we just trap ourselves in something that slowly ruins us?”

Adora couldn’t respond to that. She felt like something had stabbed at her own heart.

Glimmer sighed. “I don’t know what to do, Adora… I feel like I’m stuck. I love him so much… I love the way he holds me, I love pushing my ear against his chest and hearing his heartbeat, I love the *stupid* concern he has about my safety… But I’m scared of losing all that if I say something wrong.”

Adora had to hide her own hurt, forcing a comforting smile. “Hey. Look at me.”

Glimmer looked up at her captain, and saw the confidence she always put on around everyone.

“One awkward conversation can’t ruin all you have. Maybe that conversation might even lead to a better future? You’ll never know unless you try. You two are special to each other.”

“He *is* special. But…” Glimmer crossed her arms, wincing slightly. “Special things have always been ruined for dumb reasons.”

Adora had no way to respond to that.

The two women could only stand in silence together, listening to the sounds of the ocean and the creaking of the wood.

Glimmer was trapped between preservation and truth.

Adora knew the feeling all too well.

“We should probably head back to the deck before Bow thinks we’ve gone overboard,” Glimmer finally spoke after some time. “I appreciate you listening to… all that.”

“Of course. I’m sorry I wasn’t much help,” Adora smiled apologetically.

“You were!” Glimmer replied instantly. “Getting all this off my chest… It’s really helped me. I’ve never had anyone to speak to about this.”

"In that case, feel free to come by my quarters if you ever need to," Adora offered. "Maybe I'm not great at relationship advice, but I *am* good at listening. Especially to my friends."

Glimmer chuckled, before smiling up at her. "Thank you, captain."

"Adora! Glimmer! Wherever you are, you might want to come here and see this!"

Adora heard Bow's voice call out to her from the deck. She was quick to shift back into captain mode, her smile instantly fading as she headed towards the stairs.

Glimmer took a second to process the conversation. A second to think. A second to just… let the feelings fester in her heart, bubbling away.

She took a deep breath, and quickly followed behind her captain.

No. These feelings would have to be pushed down until later.

Adora stepped up to the deck, looking to her second mate. "What's going on?" She asked him, half-expecting another storm.

It was anything but.

Bow simply smiled. He pointed to the front of the ship. "Take a look where we are."

And when Adora looked to her right, she saw the sea ice splayed out before her.

Sheets of thin white ice floated atop the deep ocean. Large pieces, small pieces, everything in between, all laid out beautifully before Terra Nova.

Adora's eyes were wide as she walked up to the bow, putting her hands on the railings to get a closer look. The ice had a distinctive smell, almost metallic. It's light shine contrasted the deep blue of the sea, bringing out the gorgeous colour in each.

Glimmer and Bow stood alongside Adora, taking their own looks. Bow's eyes were full of wonder, his mouth hung agape as he took in the sight of the ice. He was lost in the beauty of it all.

And Glimmer was looking at someone just as beautiful. Him.

Between the sight of the ice and the sight of Bow's wonder, the choice was a no-brainer. His shifting expression from wanderlust to proudness, both of the crew and himself, was something Glimmer would never forget.

No doubt his mind was racing with it all. New things to discover, new places to try out different gear. The way his lips curled into a smile as his mind explored new possibilities…

He was beautiful in every way. And Glimmer could never get enough of it.

Silently, Adora stretched out both her arms, wrapping each one around Bow and Glimmer and pulling them close to her.

"We did it," Adora smiled. "We finally made it."

"Of course we did," Glimmer replied. "You were our captain, after all. There was never any doubt."

The crew behind them were sharing a similar view of the ice, taking a few seconds to remember this sight. Bow was still speechless, and Adora was still smiling.

But there was one inevitability they had to face.

The ice was thin, not enough to dock onto. They technically hadn't reached Antarctica yet. Actual land was still a ways off, and

as beautiful as this sea ice was, there was one thing they had to do to it.

"We're going to have to break through all that."

Bow and Glimmer looked to Adora as her tone changed, going from an almost childlike delight to dead seriousness in less than a few seconds. It's like she only allowed herself to be joyful for just a minute.

People needed her as a *captain*, not as Adora. That was always in the front of her mind.

Bow and Glimmer could only look with some worry. This was Adora's childhood dream, and yet she was forcing herself to be this Navy captain at this moment. She forced herself to be this symbol of hope for the crew.

They couldn't help but wonder if that's what Adora really wanted to be. If that's what she *chose* to be.

But they knew Adora would never give them a clear answer.

Adora quickly walked away from the bow, heading back to the crew. "All hands, prepare to break through that ice!"

The crew responded with various affirmations, immediately heading away from the ledges and going to their respective stations. Many headed down into the engine room, preparing the steam-powered ship to burst through the sea ice.

Terra Nova was a polar ship. Although she was mostly made of wood, she was also reinforced around the waterline with double planking and strengthening cross members, with bands of iron wrapped around the outside and metal sheets at the bow.

With enough force, she'd be able to break through any sea ice without causing any damage to the sea. But it wouldn't be a quick process.

Adora watched as the ice got closer and closer, Terra Nova pushing harder through the ocean. This first hit needed to be perfect.

"Brace for impact!" Adora called out loudly. The captain gripped on tight, and so did the crew.

And eventually, they struck the ice.

To Adora's firm relief, there wasn't too much whiplash. A few of the crew nearly lost their balance, but they were quick to regain it as the ship lost a lot of its speed.

Terra Nova began to push through the ice, gradually slowing to a steady pace as she chugged through. If they were to maintain this speed, it would be smooth sailing.

But the only problem was that the ice stretched on further than Adora could see. How *long* would it take to get through all this?

"Be ready to keep at this!" Adora called out. "We could be in this ice for a while!"

She remembered passages from Mara's books about the ice, how it delayed ships by days and even weeks. Adora could only hope it wouldn't be too long.

Every second in this ice was a second she was delayed from being in Antarctica.

And delayed from seeing Catra.

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*December 31, 1910.*

The sound of laughter mixed with the smell of alcohol filled Fram's cramped saloon, and Catra loved every bit of it.

It was New Year's Eve, and she'd managed to pull herself away from her duties for just a small while to share a drink with her

crew below deck. She was limiting herself obviously, no one needs a drunk captain. Besides, Catra always found she never really *needed* to drink to have a good time.

And to be a good storyteller.

"So let me get this straight," one of the women on the crew asked Catra. "This crew of grown-fucking-men is about to drive this ship straight into a shoal?"

Catra stood on a table at the front of the saloon, towering over everyone else. All eyes were directed to her as she told her story.

"To be fair, we *were* in a thick fog. But I could see it from where I was standing!" Catra replied. "This was just a passenger ship, so I was expected to stay down with the other passengers like some good little girl. But there was *no fucking way* I was dying because of some incompetent crew! So I stood up, went up to the deck and told them to slow the *hell* down before they hit the shoal and end up with a hole in the hull!"

"You just went up on deck to tell everyone off? And you were… how old?" The crew waited in anticipation for the answer.

Catra chuckled. "Sixteen."

The laughter that followed fuelled Catra's storytelling abilities. "Picture a sixteen-year-old girl screaming at a grown crew to slow down and divert their path! And they *listened* to me, too!"

The saloon was filled with more laughter and a few cheers for their captain. Catra took a small swig of her gin to cleanse her throat from the loud storytelling.

"Best part is," Catra continued, "I was so panicked, I forgot to translate myself to English for a few seconds. So not only is this sixteen-year-old Norwegian girl screaming at a bunch of grown British officers, but she's screaming out *'Hva faen gjør du, fittetryne?!'"*

More laughter erupted from the crew, and Catra couldn't help but join them slightly. She let out a long, proud sigh as the laughter slowly died down.

"Anyway, the captain was *somehow* impressed enough with me that I got offered a spot as crew on that ship during the next expedition. It was only a passenger ship, but it was experience nonetheless," Catra shrugged. "And from that moment on, the rest is history."

The crew nodded appreciatively, and eventually, one of them raised their drink in the air.

"A toast to our captain!" They called out, and the crew raised their drinks also. "And a toast to the South Pole!"

Catra was proud of the enthusiasm among her crew as they all took a drink to the captain and the destination. But there was one more thing that needed toasting.

Catra scanned the room for her, and she stuck out like a sore thumb among the pile of people in the saloon. Catra raised her drink into the air.

"And a toast to the special person who has been with me through thick and thin in the last eight years!" Catra called out vaguely.

But everyone knew who she was talking about.

All eyes in the room turned the other direction towards that special someone, sitting near the end of the room in her own little spot.

Scorpia's eyes widened as she realised *everyone* was looking to her.

"Oh, who, me?" Scorpia pointed to herself.

"No, I meant Jesus Christ himself," Catra snorted.

"… Really?"

"Of course I mean you! Get up here!" Catra waved her first mate over, grinning down at her.

"S-Sure!" Scorpia called back, quickly hopping up and stepping in between the groups of crewmates, giving the occasional 'sorry' and 'excuse me' and 'oops, didn't see your toes there' as she made her way up to the captain.

Scorpia eventually made it up the front of the saloon, and looked up to see Catra extending a hand down to her, that same encouraging grin on her face.

Scorpia could only look in awe at her captain, the confidence emanating from Catra being as intoxicating as the gin she held in her hand.

Scorpia took Catra's hand, and she felt herself lifted up onto the table with her, standing in front of the large crowd along with her captain.

"Where's Entrapta?" Catra quietly asked Scorpia.

"Oh, I think she's in her lab. She wished you well, but… she didn't want to come down," Scorpia replied.

Catra nodded. "I see."

The captain cleared her throat, looking back to the crew with the same grin as she raised her drink one last time and wrapped her arm around her first mate.

"A toast to Scorpia, our first mate who's been with me through it all over the last eight years!"

The crew returned the gesture as they raised their own drinks to the first mate. Scorpia chuckled, waving her hands. "Oh, please, you really don't- oh, thank you so much, wow…" She blabbered out.

Among all the celebration and cheer in the room, Catra did one last thing to seal the toast.

In less than a few seconds, Catra quickly leaned over and placed a kiss on Scorpia's cheek.

Scorpia blinked, her cheeks flushing in an instant as she looked to the captain. The rest of the crew mostly laughed it off. Catra, however, was grinning up at Scorpia, giving a wink as she let out a high-pitched, adorable laughter.

Catra quickly jumped down from the table to join the rest of the crew, leaving Scorpia standing alone at the table, brushing her cheek in a stunned silence. Her heart was beating four times faster than it was a minute ago.

She had to excuse herself for a few seconds.

Hopping down from the table, Scorpia quickly weaved her way through the crowd once more, her large size coming in handy for pushing through people at least.

Once she had made her way towards the stairs and up to the deck, she quickly inhaled a breath of fresh air, trying to calm herself amidst this fluttering in her chest.

She wasn't one for running away from anything, but after what just happened, she needed to collect herself. 'Push down those feelings', as she said to herself every morning.

"Oh, hi there, Scorpia!"

"GAH!" Scorpia jolted slightly as she snapped her head to the source of the noise.

It was just Entrapta. Her hands against the railing as she looked over the starboard side of the ship.

"Did I startle you too?" Entrapta wondered aloud as Scorpia faced her. "Wow, you and Catra are really jumpy."

"Sorry, I thought you'd be in your lab," Scorpia explained with a chuckle as she tried to calm her heart, which was beating even faster now. "Did you change your mind about coming down?"

"Oh… No," Entrapta shook her head plainly. "I just wanted to look at all this sea ice around the ship. It's *fascinating*."

Scorpia turned to face the ocean, finally spotting the bits of sea ice that surrounded Fram. It wasn't a solid mass, but instead broken pieces that were easy to sail around.

"We've sure been lucky to avoid anything major," Scorpia observed. "I've heard of ships being stuck breaking sea ice for weeks."

"There's been occasional bits of ice we've had to break through, but for the most part, we've had a clear ocean," Entrapta smiled. "I knew approaching from the south-east was the better path!"

Scorpia was glad to see Entrapta's smile. When she took pride in her work, her joy was infectious. Entrapta's whole personality was infectious really. It was like the bubbles from her heart spilled out and filled Scorpia with excitement and wonder.

She just wished she could see Entrapta's smile more often.

Entrapta's happiness was enough to distract Scorpia for a few seconds. But only a few seconds.

"So why did you burst out of the saloon with a blush on your face whilst rubbing your cheek?" Entrapta soon asked with the same bluntness as usual.

Scorpia didn't think she was being *that* obvious. Or maybe Entrapta could just read body language at superhuman levels.

Probably the latter.

The first mate sighed. "Just… weird stuff."

"I like weird stuff!" Entrapta beamed.

"Not *that* kind of weird stuff. I…" Scorpia struggled to find the words for a few seconds. "It's hard to understand."

"Well, I can certainly *try.* That's my whole job here!"

Entrapta's encouragement was, for once, something Scorpia wasn't totally enthusiastic about. Nevertheless, she looked to the ice in the ocean, and spoke the words as they came to her mind, refusing to filter anything.

"… Catra kissed me on the cheek."

It sounded *so* pathetic out loud.

There was a silence that hung thick between the two women. Scorpia was waiting for Entrapta to laugh at her, or call that completely meaningless, or maybe ask questions she wasn't sure she could answer.

But instead, Entrapta asked something simpler.

"Ooh. So is she your girlfriend now?"

"What?!" Scorpia looked up.

"Is she-"

"No! No, no, no. Noooo. No, no. I… No! Not at all. No. I mean, if she *was*, that'd be… But she's not. At all. Never has been, never will be. And you know what? I don't *want* her to be my girlfriend."

Entrapta blinked at Scorpia.

"… Okay, that was a lie," Scorpia sighed.

"So she's not your girlfriend… But you *do* love her?" Entrapta asked.

Scorpia kept her silence for a few seconds, before hanging her head in shame.

"I do."

A relatively easy solution formed in Entrapta's mind.

"Then you should tell her that."

"No!" Scorpia immediately snapped her head up. "No, I *can't* do that!" Scorpia waved her hands.

"Why not?"

"I just can't! It's… not right!"

"Not right?"

"Look, she's my captain, I'm her first mate. It's… a professional relationship, and it can't be any more!" Scorpia spoke words that she didn't really mean. It was like she was a puppet.

"… She just kissed you on the cheek," Entrapta replied bluntly. "That seems more than professional to me."

"No! I…"

Scorpia sighed, pushing the heels of her hands against her forehead as if to push away a headache. There was just no easy way to describe any of this.

For all intents and purposes, Entrapta *was* in the right. Scorpia had been holding onto these feelings for a long, long time, and every day was making it harder to bottle them up.

But it just wasn't that simple.

"… I'm sorry that I'm not much help," Entrapta spoke quietly.

"You are! You really are!" Scorpia quickly corrected, sensing the hurt in Entrapta's voice. "I'm just weird and stupid! People are just… imperfect! It's not your fault that this is all confusing. I doubt *anyone* can ever fully understand…" She wiggles her hands. "All this."

A silence followed. Scorpia, amidst all this love-stricken panic, was now worried she'd hurt Entrapta as well. And Scorpia never wanted to hurt anyone she cared for.

She almost wanted to hug Entrapta, but eventually, the second mate put on a soft smile as she looked up.

"Well, I think imperfection is beautiful," Entrapta spoke in a tone much more delicate and softer than Scorpia was used to. "And I think your love for Catra is beautiful, too."

Scorpia took in those words in a stunned silence for a second or two. "You really think that?"

"You and Catra… Your bond is amazing. This ship *relies* on you two. You're like the coal that fills the furnace in the engine room, igniting in passion and wonder!" Entrapta said with fascination in her voice.

This was… unexpected language from her.

She seemed supportive. But there was one major questioning lingering in Scorpia's mind.

"And… you don't mind that I love a woman?" Scorpia continued.

"No. Why would I mind that?" Entrapta spoke like Scorpia had just asked the most obvious question of all time.

"Because… Most people would think that it's not right…?"

“I find that ‘most people’ tend to be wrong about a lot of things. Love between same-sex couples happens all the time, especially in the animal kingdom!” Entrapta spoke with a smile.

“Really?” Scorpia asked, this being the first she’d ever heard of this.

“Yes! In fact, there was a report released last year about Adélie penguins where it was noted that two male penguins mating together was a common behaviour,” Entrapta spoke with the excited tone that comes with scientific explanation.

“I… I didn’t know about that,” Scorpia admitted.

“Well, the report was privately released for specific researchers, not to the general public,” Entrapta explained. “Plus, for some reason, the only copies of that report made available to researchers were all translated into *Greek*. It was like they didn’t *want* people to know that information. I was able to translate it well enough, though.”

“… I see,” Scorpia said, before smiling. “I’m glad you’ve got our back then. Thank you.”

“That’s okay!” Entrapta beamed. “You’re... my friend, right?”

“Of course,” Scorpia smiled.

“Well, friends should always have each other’s backs. At least, I think that’s how it works…” Entrapta rubbed her chin, before shaking her head. “Either way. I’m here for you.”

“You’ve really helped me with… all this,” Scorpia smiled, wiggling her hands once more.

More than anything, *those* were the words that made Entrapta smile the most. And as always, that smile bubbled over into Scorpia’s heart.

With her confidence back, Scorpia headed for the door, beginning to head down to the saloon.

"Are you going to talk to Catra now?" Entrapta asked.

"Oh, I…" Scorpia chuckled, scratching the back of her head. "Not tonight. But maybe later. Happy New Year, Entrapta!"

Entrapta didn't get a chance to respond before Scorpia had already turned to head down into the saloon to celebrate with the others. She could hear laughter, dancing, and liquid being spilled, all the sounds echoing up to the deck.

Even from up here, all the noise gave Entrapta an unnerving feel. She'd love to be down there with everyone else, but her mind became cluttered and pounding at the idea of all that sounds and lights.

So, Entrapta looked back out at the ocean with much to reflect on. Scorpia's feelings, most of all. Scorpia loved Catra, but she couldn't tell her for seemingly no reason.

Love was one of those things that could never be fully solved. Entrapta knew that much. She had loved many things in her life.

Entrapta had loved people in the past. She loved her work. She loved her passions. She loved her friends especially.

But in her mind, she never knew what it was like to *be* loved.

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What was supposed to be a few days or a week had turned into Terra Nova being stuck in the ice for a little over three weeks.

Every day, Adora was expecting this endless mass of sea ice to end at that some point, but it went on further than the eye could see. Terra Nova made steady progress, but malfunctions and motivation had slowed it considerably at points.

And now it was December 31

And on that evening, for the first time, Adora could *finally* see the end of the sea ice.

"Steady does it!" Adora called out to her crew as she approached the front of the ship, seeing the end of the sea ice approaching ever so slowly. "Give the engines a bit more fuel for the last push!"

Adora had walked between the engine room, the steering wheel, the masts and the front of the ship at least two-dozen times by now. Everything seemed to be in working order for this break, and the crew's motivation had shot up immensely.

Once they were clear of this sea ice, it was almost a straight shot to Antarctica.

"Almost there…!" Adora called out as the edge got closer. "Everyone brace!"

"Aye!" The crew called back as Adora gripped the ledge, readying herself for the breakage. The freedom. The ocean, once more.

Three whole weeks in ice, with barely a second to rest. All of it would finally be behind them. Adora *desperately* needed to get rid of the bags under her eyes.

And soon, they'd be in the land of her dreams. Soon, they'd be in Antarctica.

It was enough to give Adora a smile as she finally heard the last crack of the ice and felt the ship surge, the hull crashing into the ocean and rocking the ship back and forth.

Cheers emanated throughout the deck as the ocean water splashed up onto the deck, most of it splattering onto Adora and soaking her clothes and hair. And yet, not a drop dampened her mood. She grinned as she looked over her shoulder, seeing the path Terra Nova had carved through the ice that stretched on for miles.

“Good work, crew!” Adora called out. “Keep her slow and steady from here! We shouldn’t be more than a few days out from Antarctica!”

The crew replied with a more enthusiastic affirmation, and with the ice gone, Adora finally had a few minutes to herself to simply stand and take in the view.

She hadn’t been able to admire anything in weeks.

It was early evening of the last day of 1910. The sky was rosy, colours varying from burnished copper to salmon pink, with icebergs in the distance having a pale greenish hue and deep purple shadows.

The calm sea beneath them gently soothed Terra Nova after the roughness of the ice, and for the first time in three weeks, Adora’s legs weren’t jittering with the destruction of ice beneath them.

The air was sweet with a mint scent, and Adora’s breath formed into pale condensation before her.

These were the sights she came all this way for.

As Adora turned to head back to the engine room, she spotted something else on the port side of the ship. Two people, finally resting from weeks of hard work, watching the distant ice and blue water.

Bow and Glimmer, standing side by side.

They seemed to be talking to each other, a smile on each of their faces as they watched the sky and the sea. They were close. Really close.

Adora thought about her talk with Glimmer from three weeks back. Had anything changed since then? Did the ice distract her too much? Would she ever tell Bow how she felt?

Only time would tell. For now, they had each other's joyous company. Even without a relationship, Adora could tell they truly loved each other just as people.

She watched them for the happiness that they gave off.

But she also watched them because, deep within, she wished she could have what they had.

Adora hated when she got like this, but it never went away. She loved Bow and Glimmer, and she loved their friendship. But the envy was always there.

It was to be a New Year. 1911.

And Adora wished she had a certain person to celebrate it with.

# Promise Part 5

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Adora reach their destination. In the past, a separation.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

*January 15, 1911.*

"I can smell it."

"Smell what?"

"Land ahead."

Catra stood alongside Entrapta and Scorpia at the front of Fram, looking out towards the ocean and icebergs. If the calculations and mapping were to be believed, today was going to be the day.

The day they finally reached Antarctica.

Catra had her hands behind her back—her eyes closed and her chin tilted up—as she took in a deep breath through her nose. "Yes… I guarantee it. Land ahead."

Scorpia returned with a few sniffs of her own, raising an eyebrow and putting on a not-so-confident smile. "Right! I… can smell it too. Definitely. That… land-y smell. Smell o' land. Land smell."

Catra chuckled. "You don't have to pretend, Scorpia. It's alright. I just have a particular nose for these things," she said, tapping the side of her own nose. "Any second now…"

Scorpia could see the excited smile on Catra's face—that look of confidence, pride and anticipation—curved up into her gorgeous,

squishable cheeks, her chest puffing up with a much-earned bravado.

Surrounded by a beautiful ocean, Scorpia found herself staring at someone even more beautiful.

“Is the cargo set to be moved?” Catra asked Entrapta, looking to her second mate.

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded. “The dogs will move everything until we can find a safe terrain to make our stay in. Framheim can be erected from there.”

“Framheim? You mean that hut that was meant for observation?” Scorpia queried, having not heard that name for a while.

“That’s the one,” Catra replied. “It was just meant for temporary stay and observation when our original goal was the North Pole, but now it’s our home for the next ten months.”

“It’ll need some obvious improvements for such a long-term stay, but I already have some ideas brewing!” Entrapta raised a finger.

“So we already have a home, but we need to make it feel… *more* like home?” Scorpia clarified.

“That’s the idea!” Entrapta replied. “We have everything we need to erect the hut, it’s all packed on the sleds. Once it’s set up, we can get to work planning ways to add onto it and improve it.”

Framheim seemed to be a project to keep the crew busy during the cold Winter months, which would last from March to November at the latest. Scorpia had never really worked in architecture, but if it gave her something to *do*, especially alongside Catra, she could hardly complain.

The many months in the freezing cold would be enough time for reflection, contemplation, and most of all, conversation. Conversations about goals, life, and… well, maybe even love.

Of course, the idea of being in a long Antarctic winter cramped in a warm hut with her crush definitely had Scorpia feeling both joyous and *incredibly* anxious. By this time next year, maybe they'd be more than just captain and first mate. More than just friends.

Maybe she'd finally be able to tell Catra-

"Ah. *There* you are."

Scorpia blinked, her train of thought being cut by Catra's raw, excited voice.

She looked up to see the deep blue ocean, the distant white of the icebergs…

And the solid sheet of ice that covered the land of Antarctica.

Catra grinned, for she had finally reached her destination.

For a while, neither Catra, Scorpia nor Entrapta could speak as they looked out to the Great Ice Barrier, the largest ice shelf in Antarctica. Even the crew were relatively quiet, all sixty pairs of eyes looking towards their destination.

Almost three months ago, the decision had been made to turn Fram towards the south. Rarely any stops had been made, and they had been immensely lucky to avoid storms and thick ice.

The air was freezing, and Catra could see her soft gasps form into condensation before her. It wouldn't be getting much warmer than

this. Her nose was numb and red.

And she loved *every bit of it.*

"Prepare the crew for docking," Catra said quietly to her first and second mate. "And ready the bridge. Us three are going to be the first to set foot on the ice."

Scorpia and Entrapta didn't even get a chance to respond as Catra began to head towards the starboard side of the ship, leaving them to sort out the docking stations.

They could handle themselves fine. Catra just needed one thing before she went anywhere. One thing to mark her first step on Antarctica. One thing to make this truly special.

Catra headed towards her quarters. Down the stairs and through the heavy door. Everything in her quarters would be moved out in time—most of her room was already cleared out anyway.

But there was still one thing she hadn't packed away yet.

Laying upon her bed was the reason all of this was done in the first place. The reason she had some all this way. The reason for so much joy, and so much pain.

Laying upon her bed was the silver promise ring.

Catra picked it up, holding it in the palm of her hand. She took a moment to just look. To just remember.

Remember her past. Remember the reason. And remember the promise that saved her and *broke* her.

She could feel the ship slowly coming to a halt, and the calls of her crew as they docked by the ice. Fram's anchor sunk into the icy ocean, and eventually, the ship came to a still.

It was time.

Catra took the chain that was looped through the ring, and put it over her neck, tucking the ring under her shirt and wearing it like a necklace. No one would be able to see it.

But she could feel it. And that's all that mattered.

Ascending up the stairs once more, Catra saw the crew lowering the wooden bridge from the ship onto the ice shelf, careful not to break anything or go too fast. Scorpia and Entrapta waited by the bridge, their eyes looking to their captain.

In fact, Catra was being looked at by almost everyone. This was *her* dream, after all. No one was taking it away from her.

Catra crossed the deck towards the bridge, keeping her breath steady but feeling her heart beat rapidly. She looked to her first and second mate. Her crew. Her friends.

And with a shared nod, the three of them stepped onto the bridge.

The wind blew against them, and Scorpia winced slightly. It was ice cold, and the breeze took Catra's hair and flung it to the side. It almost felt like they'd be blown off the bridge.

But Catra persisted. Step after step, she headed towards the ice. The bridge was short, and yet it felt so long. Every step triggered a memory in Catra's mind.

A memory of the promise, made on a freezing morning as the sun rose in the distance.

A memory of an awkward first dinner, and yet Catra's bravery persisting.

A memory of her first drive, and false promise.

A memory of holding Adora in her arms and trusting her future to her—a fatal mistake.

And a memory of their separation, a day Catra would always regret.

Soon enough, she saw that the next step was the most important one. A large sheet of ice beneath the tip of the bridge, ready for her. This was the last chance to turn back.

Like hell she would.

Scorpia and Entrapta held back, letting the captain collect herself for a few seconds. She took a deep breath in through her nose, letting the icy cold air sit for a while, before letting that breath out through her mouth.

There was only one thing left to do.

Catra stepped forward with her right foot, and placed it firmly on Antarctica.

It was like every nerve in her spine suddenly flared, bringing about immeasurable tingles and a lifting sensation in her stomach. She could barely focus on anything else but this step as she brought her left foot forward.

Both feet on Antarctica. She was on Antarctica. She was standing on Antarctica. She was breathing in Antarctica.

Catra Horda was in Antarctica.

Scorpia was the second to follow, leaping from the bridge and onto the ice. She felt like a kid again, stepping onto new land with immense excitement. She let out a hearty laugh as she felt the cold beneath her feet.

Entrapta was third to step onto the ice, letting out a long gasp as she looked around at the blue sky, endless ice, and distant bergs.

It was endless opportunity for discovery—flora, fauna, and beauty all in one place.

"We made it…" Scorpia scoffed, almost in disbelief. "We really made it. I can't believe it…"

"I have to admit, I thought we were going to be turned around at least sixty times in the last three months," Entrapta stated. "But we're here… The ice just goes on forever…"

"I bet you're thinking about the amount of penguins out there," Scorpia chuckled.

"And a way to find them all…" Entrapta replied, her eyes wide and her smile even wider as she looked around.

But soon, they both noticed their captain shaking.

Catra's head was tilted down, her whole body shivering. They couldn't tell if the shaking was because of the cold, the sorrow, or the joy. They were both—admittedly—a tad bit worried. Catra has never shaken like this.

Catra clenched her fists tight, Scorpia was the first to notice. She almost wanted to reach out and give Catra a hug, either to calm her, warm her or make sure she's still okay. Was this overwhelming her?

"Captain…" Entrapta asked delicately as Scorpia reached out a hand.

But eventually, Catra looked back up. There wasn't a single tear in her eye, nor was she feeling particularly cold. There was only one reason for her shaking.

She took in a breath…

And then, Catra screamed.

At first, the crew were convinced their captain had gone completely insane. Catra tilted her head up, letting out that scream and filling the endless ice with it. It echoed on for miles.

Scorpia and Entrapta both flinched, the noise jarring them. Catra wasn't screaming with fear or rage or anything. She was just… screaming.

But slowly, the scream pitched higher and higher as Catra ran out of air. And Scorpia stared with wide eyes to see…

That Catra was *smiling* as she screamed.

Slowly, that scream turned into the most joyful laughter anyone on Fram had ever heard.

Catra let out a big, high-pitched, heart-filled laughter, raising her arms in the air as if to challenge the gods themselves. She took a few steps ahead.

"THAT'S RIGHT!" She yelled at no one in the current vicinity. "You all never believed in me! You all thought I'd never make it! You all thought I'd amount to nothing! Well, guess what?!"

She pounded her fist against her chest. "Here I am! Here I am, HERE I AM, *HERE I FUCKING AM!"* She belted as she fell to her knees, the joy throwing her off balance as she laughed.

"I'm in Antarctica! I'm going to reach the South Pole, I'm going to see Aurora Australis, I'm going to be remembered forever, and you can't do a *fucking* thing about it!"

And eventually, she ran out of breath.

Crumbled on her knees, ice against her shin, lungs lacking air, Catra took in everything about Antarctica. It was nothing like the dreams she had of it, and she still *loved* it. She hadn't felt this much joy in years.

She could hear her crew celebrating behind her, that joy having infected them. They knew the words weren't directed at them specifically. Even Entrapta couldn't help but laugh, all the beautiful sounds filling Catra's ears.

But Catra had a few more words for just one person.

Slowly, Catra raised a hand and pressed it against her collarbone, feeling the outline of the ring against her palm.

She whispered one last thing to herself.

"And soon, you'll be here too… Just like we promised."

The thought filled her heart with warmth.

However, with those words, Catra's smile faded. She wasn't frowning, nor was she sad. She was simply… neutral. This was one of the best days of her life, after all. She was physically incapable of being sad.

And yet, she *was* missing the very person that would make it *the* best day of her life.

"So…" Scorpia's voice spoke as she eventually walked up to Catra, who still on her knees. "Want me to organise the gear and crew? Give you a minute to… catch your breath?"

Catra held onto the ring as she heard those words, and slowly, she nodded. "Thank you."

Scorpia noticed the ring in Catra's hand. She'd seen it a few times, but never before had Catra held it so dearly to herself. Was it some sort of good luck charm, she wondered?

"Where'd you get that from?" Scorpia asked out of general curiosity, pointing to the ring.

Catra looked down to it once more. She wasn't sure how to feel. All of this was confusing. It had been years since they separated,

and the anger from that day had mellowed out into guilt, longing and regret. But she had no idea if Adora felt the same.

She gave one response to Scorpia—a response she thought nothing of.

"It's from Adora."

When she spoke this time, Catra chose to smile.

Maybe she'd feel different when she saw Adora. Maybe that anger would all come back. Maybe she *was* right to leave Adora. Maybe she should've never had this ring in the first place.

Catra couldn't figure out how she felt about Adora.

But for now, Catra smiled *because* of Adora.

Among all her thoughts, there was one thing Catra failed to notice as she looked to the ring.

She never look to her left in that moment.

She never saw Scorpia's face when she heard that name.

She never noticed that when Scorpia heard those words, her heart dropped.

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*January 18, 1911.*

Adora knew she was getting talked about behind her back by her crew.

It had been a couple of weeks since they broke the ice, and it had even been a few days since they encountered the ice shelf of Antarctica.

For all intents and purposes, they *had* arrived at Antarctica. They'd been here for a while. And yet, they still hadn't docked.

Adora had made her intentions clear—she wanted to survey the land nearby to find the right spot to the dock at, as well as make notes of any locations of interest. Penguin colonies, flora to look into, and Bow especially was interested in mapping out places to dig into and discover unique minerals.

But they drove around the ice shelf almost aimlessly. That's all they'd been doing for the last few days. They hadn't spotted anything of note.

With so much time to sit around and talk, word was slowly going around that the captain had an ulterior motive to this seemingly meaningless sailing.

Word that Adora was looking for something...

"… Or *someone*," Glimmer finished.

Adora took in her first mate's words as she looked out to the ice shelf, her hands on the railing of the ship. She took a gentle breath in through her nose. "I appreciate you raising the crew's concerns with me, Glimmer."

"They're not *just* the crew's, sir. They're mine too," said Glimmer with a sharpness to her voice. "What the hell are you looking for? Why all this sailing? Why haven't we docked yet? This is turning out to be pointless, and you're losing everyone's trust. Fast."

Adora could always rely on Glimmer for her brutal honesty, at least.

She turned to face her first mate. "Do you know how long it is until that sun sets?"

Glimmer nodded. "About two months."

"Once it sets, we're going to be in complete darkness for six months," Adora said. "And after that, there's going to be *no* chance to survey anything or go anywhere. Before that sun sets,

we need to know where everything is, plan out what we need to do before the sky goes dark, and most importantly…"

Adora narrowed her eyes as she looked back to the land.

"We need to find Mara Hope."

Once the sun was down, all hope of successfully locating Mara would be lost. She had enough supplies to last one winter, but there was no chance she'd make it through two. Adora needed to rescue her before then.

Surveillance gave her an early chance to locate Mara, or anything that can help before March was over. She had planned thoroughly for this trip. There was no such thing as a 'pointless' move in Adora's itinerary.

"Alright, I understand that," Glimmer said. "So *now* you can cut the bullshit. There's someone else you're looking for, isn't there?"

Glimmer could see through the act.

Adora didn't even flinch. She only hung her head in shame, sighing. "I *am* doing everything I just said. Mara is a high priority, and we *do* need to plot out our every move for the next couple of months."

"I don't doubt that. The crew understand that much," Glimmer said. "What I'm saying is, there's one more thing you're looking for. One more *person* you're looking for. And yet you're too ashamed to tell everyone because this person isn't exactly a priority, isn't she? She's someone important to just *you*."

Those words turned into acid that began to eat away at Adora's conscience.

It's not like Adora was jeopardising the whole trip just to find her, but Glimmer was right. There was another reason for all this in the back of her mind, a reason that never quite left ever since she got that letter a few months back.

Adora had made a selfish decision. She knew everyone would hate her for it. She hated herself for it. But she made it nonetheless. Because…

"Catra's out there somewhere."

Adora admitted it, plain and simple.

Glimmer folded her arms, letting out a sigh as she looked to the ice shelf. "It would probably help the crew if they knew that, Adora. No matter how embarrassing it is for you, the truth would at least get them to trust you more."

What do *they* know? That was the first thought that came to Adora's mind. They don't know the first thing about her relationship to Catra. They have no idea how much Adora has sacrificed to be here. How can *they* judge her?

But as always, Adora kept those thoughts tucked away. And the more she dwelled on those thoughts, the more they began to eat away at her.

"You said Catra was your friend," Glimmer pointed out, looking to her captain. "But you haven't seen her in eight years. What's the big deal about finding her now? How special is she really?"

*More than you can imagine.*

Adora couldn't find the right words to say. She couldn't even understand her *own* feelings. Her separation from Catra was agonising, and it had only been followed by eight years of silence between them. Eight years of guilt and regret.

So why does she care so damn much about Catra?

After all this time, was she really worth all this?

"Captain! I've got something in my sight!"

Adora's head snapped up as she looked to the spotter high up in the mast, spyglass against her eyes as she looked ahead.

"What do you see?" Adora asked her crewmate.

"It's…" The crewmate focused a bit more. "It's a ship, docked ahead!"

Adora looked to the front of Terra Nova, quickly making her way to the front of the deck to get a closer look. A ship could mean Mara's location, and a quick chance at rescue.

Or it could mean something else.

Adora eventually saw the ship come into clearer view. It was a beautiful one, with three high masts and greenheart wood on its outer layer. Multiple crew members surrounded the ship and the land docked near it, seemingly transporting cargo with a team of dogs.

And just as soon as Adora saw the design, she saw something else. Something on those large masts, flailing with the heavy wind.

Norwegian flags.

This wasn't Mara's ship.

This was Fram.

This was *Catra's ship.*

Adora looked from the ship to the Norwegian crew on the land. She scanned the forty-or-so people transporting wooden crates and heavy equipment.

"Where are you…?" Adora whispered to herself as she scanned person after person.

Eventually, everyone on land began to notice the presence of a British ship. Fram's crew all turned to face her, and with that, Adora could see their eyes.

And when Adora could see their eyes, she could finally spot *hers.*

Her eyes always stuck out among the rest, after all.

Her eyes.

Her *eyes.*

Adora suddenly realised *she was looking right into her eyes.*

It was like…

Time had stopped.

Like nothing else in the world mattered but this moment.

Like no one else existed except for these two women, right here, right now.

Like everything was leading to *this*.

This very moment of eye contact.

A wave of emotions crashed over their hearts and swept them away into the land of bittersweet memories.

She still had the most beautiful eyes, even after all this time.

Standing on the ice shelf, being the first to notice Terra Nova, being the one to freeze as soon as she made eye contact with Adora…

Was Catra Horda herself.

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*December 15, 1902.*

Adora looked at the silver ring in her hand, and her heart felt like it was being torn in half.

She'd been building herself up to this day for nearly a whole three months now. Every time she felt like saying it, she cowered out. But it needed to be done. There was no other option.

She tried to push these feelings down to make things easier for Catra. She *tried*. But Adora was so, so tired.

She needed to tell Catra the truth. Today.

She stood before a recently purchased house on the English countryside. The weather was oddly beautiful for what would be turn out to be an ugly day. The house still looked brand new—clean, tidied up, and even with a forest nearby to explore.

It was a nice place. Adora didn't know it'd be the last time she ever visited it.

She raised a fist and—with her hands shaking—she knocked on the front door of the home before her.

Maybe she wouldn't be here today. Maybe Adora could find some excuse to delay this again, like she'd been doing the last month.

Maybe…

She soon heard a few footsteps approach the door.

No. There was no avoiding this. No running away.

The door clicked, and when it opened, Adora was met with Catra's eyes peering around the corner.

"Hey, Adora," Catra smiled. "I… I wasn't expecting you."

"Hey-"

Adora was interrupted as Catra wrapped her arms around her partner. She could only just return the hug, putting a hand on Catra's back. It barely felt like an embrace—more like some sort of formality.

"Hey, Catra."

Catra separated from her girlfriend, keeping her hands on her arm and rubbing her bicep up and down like she always did. She was always so *comfortable* around Adora.

"What brings you here? Did you like yesterday's house tour so much that you decided to come live with me now?" Catra chuckled, half-joking but almost serious. "I'm still unpacking everything to move in, but I can make room."

Adora returned the laughter, but there was no heart in it. "Unfortunately, no… I actually came here to tell you something."

"Sure," Catra smiled. "Do you want to come in? I've got the kettle boiling and-"

"No, no, it's… It's alright," Adora shook her head, playing with the ring in her hands. She couldn't make eye contact.

She cut Catra off. She never usually did that. Catra raised an eyebrow.

"… Adora, what's wrong?" Catra asked. "You're being… really quiet."

Adora knew that tone of voice. The concern for her well-being. The genuine *love*.

It made this all the more painful.

"I…" Adora cleared her throat. "I got my results back from my training a few days ago. I passed. I'm officially a ranked officer in the Navy."

Catra blinked, her eyes widening. "I… Wow. Well, it's not like I doubted you, but still… You're really going that far for our promise, huh?"

Adora needed to look up. She needed to look into Catra's eyes, but she just *couldn't*.

"Did you come all the way out here just to tell me that?" Catra asked. "I mean, it's a long trip, isn't it? Is there something more?"

Catra sounded *excited*, somehow. Like she was expecting Adora to actually move in with her. Like any of this would have a happy ending.

Adora felt a slug in her throat. A weight in her gut. Her whole body was shaking and her heart was racing out of her chest. Every passing second only worsened the anxiety.

She never wanted to do this. But there was no way forward. She had to push through the pain now, or it'll just drag on forever.

Adora took a deep breath. Slowly, she extended her hand out, holding the silver ring before Catra.

"I came to give this back to you."

Silence.

Adora couldn't look up. She couldn't look into Catra's eyes. *Nothing in the world* could've made her look into Catra's eyes.

The gentle wind was the only sound to accompany those words. After a while, she wasn't even sure if Catra was breathing—everything was so damn quiet. She could see her legs, frozen stiff.

She could only imagine what Catra's expression was like. Shock? Anger? Heartbreak? Adora couldn't look up.

"I... Catra, I tried. I promise, I *tried*." Adora's voice sounded so exhausted. "I really tried to find a way for us to keep this promise. I wanted nothing more than to see that smile on your face.

Adora sighed. "But… we have to fact the facts. This is all just too *hard*. I know neither one of us wanted to admit it, but it's just the truth. And the truth fucking *hurts*, Catra. Look, maybe one of us will make it to the South Pole. Maybe one of us will see Aurora Australis. But both of us? At the same time? I just…"

As Adora spoke, she slowly felt Catra take the ring from her hand. For the first time in over seven years, the ring was no longer in Adora's possession.

With the ring gone, it felt like a tremendous weight had been lifted off her back. And she *hated* that she felt like that.

"I'm sorry, Catra…" Adora whispered with a tremor in her voice.

The silence was agonising. Catra hadn't spoken for the last minute, and she had barely moved. Adora felt like her heart was being crushed by the guilt.

"… Why didn't you tell me this sooner?" Catra finally spoke in a low tone. The tone of pure disappointment. "If you couldn't keep your promise… Why did you keep my hopes up for so long?"

"Because I really thought we'd *actually* make it at first. There were doubts, but I tried to push them away. I thought things would turn out fine if we kept going," Adora explained. "But after a while… I realised it was just too hard. But then I was just too scared to admit that, because I never, *ever* wanted to hurt you. God, that's the last thing I ever want in my life. So I kept quiet to protect you."

Adora let out a shaky sigh. "But I should've told you I was having doubts earlier. I'm sorry."

Catra remained silent. She was still looking at the ring in her hand, Adora could tell. That ring meant *everything* to her.

"But…" Adora took a breath, a hopeful one. "Even if I can't keep that promise… That doesn't mean *we* have to be over. We can't just let something like this ruin us. I mean, you still love me, right?"

A glimmer of hope sparked in Adora's heart and—finally—she decided to take the risk and look up. Maybe Catra would be disappointed or sad, but it can't be *that* bad.

So, Adora looked up into Catra's eyes.

Oh.

Oh, *god*.

She *immediately* wished she hadn't.

Tears were streaming down Catra's cheeks from her stinging, red eyes.

Her face was mix of hurt, anger, sadness and betrayal. She was silently crying, gripping the ring in her hand, her face twitching and her lips wobbling as she returned Adora's eye contact with fury.

"Do I still love you…?" Catra asked as if it was the stupidest question she had ever heard. Likely because it was.

"Catra, I know it hurts. Trust me, I *know.* But it was a promise we made when I turned thirteen. We can't just let it dictate our whole relationship!" Adora spoke plainly. "I know it's painful, but that's just the way life is sometimes."

"You think I don't know that, Adora? I *know* that life is difficult. You have *no idea* how hard things have been for me. But throughout all the shit I've been through, *you* kept my hopes up for nearly eight years. *You* kept saying over and over again that 'we'd find a way'. *You* kept saying that you'd keep your promise. I actually *trusted* you…" Catra grit her teeth. "Now you just throw it all in my fucking face. And you're asking if I still *love you…?*"

"Catra, I know I screwed up. I know I should've told you earlier, but-"

"Stop. Just… Just stop."

"Catra, please, *please* let's just talk about this, I am *begging* you, please-"

"For god's sake, *stop.*"

Catra's voice was filled with the most pain and hatred Adora had ever heard in her entire life.

"I don't care that you couldn't keep some promise we made when we were kids," Catra said plainly. "*That* doesn't hurt me. What hurts me is that you just… kept on going with this lie. You kept

saying ‘we’ll find a way’ over and over and over. Instead of just… talking with me like an adult, you just kept on lying to me.”

“I wasn’t lying to you,” Adora shook her head. “I thought I’d find a way, I really did! But anytime I tried to tell you that I was having doubts or worries, you’d just shut me down! Fuck, I was afraid to tell you this because I *knew* this would be how you’d react!”

“Seriously? That’s your excuse?” Catra scoffed. “I’m just too scary to talk to, so you keep on making things up to please me? Are you fucking serious?”

“I’m not making up excuses! I just…” Adora was trying to find the words to fix this. “Catra, everything I did, I did it to try and make you happy. I just wanted to see your smile-”

“Do I look like I’m fucking smiling now, Adora?!”

Her voice cracked with the ‘smiling’.

“I enrolled in the Navy for you, I gave so much for you, I…” Adora shook her head. “I love you, Catra… You have to understand, everything I did was for *you*.”

“God, you make it sound like I *tortured* you. Are you trying to guilt me?” Catra asked in horror.

“No! No, I swear-“

“I trusted you, Adora. I *trusted* you,” Catra seethed, her stinging eyes looking into Adora’s as she prodded a heavy finger at her chest.

“Catra-”

“Don’t,” Catra growled. “Don’t you ‘Catra’ me. We’re *done*. We’re *finished*. If I can’t trust you, then I can’t be with you.”

“… What?”

"You heard me," Catra muttered. "Get out of my house. I never want to see you again. I knew it was a mistake to let you get too close."

"Wait…" Adora held up her hands. "Wait, wait, wait. That is *way* too rash, Catra, you know this. Just stop and think. This is ridiculous, you can't end things like this-"

"*I just did*," Catra cut her off. "I know perfectly well what's right for me, and that's *never* seeing you again."

"Catra, you're upset. I get it. I'll just come back later and we can talk-"

"Don't. Don't ever back here again. Don't ever come back into my life," Catra seethed.

Oh.

Oh, *no*.

She was being serious.

Adora's entire face dropped. Her heart fell to her stomach.

Not like this. Not like *this.* Not after everything.

"Catra, wait…" Adora took a step closer. "Don't go. Please. Stay. I… I *need* you."

Catra looked to the ring in her hand as she heard those pained words. Adora sounded desperate—a tone she rarely had.

For a second, those words strained Catra's heart. For a second, she allowed one moment of vulnerability. For a second, she considered giving Adora another chance.

But it was only *just* a second.

"No, you don't." Catra shook her head, looking up to Adora with the eyes of regret. "You never have."

Adora's eyes were wide. This can't be happening. This *can't* be happening. This was the *one thing* she was trying to avoid, the *one thing* she fought so hard to prevent.

She never wanted to hurt Catra. Not once. Not ever.

She desperately tried to step towards Catra—tried to convince her to rethink this.

But Catra's look of tearful anger was the last thing Adora would ever see of her.

Adora stammered. "I didn't mean to…"

"I don't care. You *hurt* me, Adora."

And with that, the door slammed between them.

Adora was left with just those words. The wind rushing in her ear. The sobs that came from within the house; Catra's pained sobs that Adora could not comfort because *she* was the one that caused them.

Adora had expected a reaction from Catra. She expected her to be upset and not available for a while.

But this sudden end to their relationship? After nearly eight years? She couldn't comprehend *why*. She couldn't comprehend why Catra would end things just like that over a childhood promise.

She wanted a second chance. A do-over. She wanted to tell Catra the painful truth earlier and spare the pain. She wanted to travel back in time and fix everything. This barely felt real.

But only reality could contain this kind of pain.

Adora was left in the wind, the tears silently forming in the corners of her eyes and the tightness of pain in her throat. It was over. The ring, their future, their joy, gone in the span of a few minutes.

She had lost Catra.

And those words along were enough for Adora to let out her first agonised sob as she walked away from the house. Guilt strangled her, regret punched her gut, grief tore her heart, and self-hatred stabbed her all over.

But none of those could hurt more than the last words Catra had ever spoken to her. Everything she had tried to prevent came right back to bite her. She had failed at the one thing she never wanted to fail at.

Those final words would ring in her ears for years on end.

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*January 18, 1911.*

"… Take us in, Glimmer. We're docking next to that ship."

Glimmer looked over to her captain, seeing a look of focus, sorrow, guilt, excitement and fear, all at once. Adora's hand was

shaking, but she did her best to still it.

This situation with the captain of Fram beyond Glimmer right now. She knew it.

With a nod, Glimmer turned and ordered the crew to docking stations, not taking 'no' for an answer. She left Adora to her thoughts as Terra Nova steered towards the ice shelf.

Adora could barely remember to breathe.

This didn't feel real. Those eyes… The last time she saw those eyes, they were stinging red—full of anger and tears.

And now they were looking right at her. Wide, shocked, and almost in awe.

Adora kept that eye contact for only a few seconds, before stepping away from the ledge and towards the middle of the deck. She needed to see Catra closer. She needed to set foot on the ice and come face-to-face with her.

Starting today, she needed to do this *right.*

Terra Nova swung around slowly, port side to the ice shelf. The anchor slowly dropped, and the bridge dropped down from the ledge onto the ice shelf. There was a fair distance between Terra Nova and Fram, as to avoid collision.

For a few moments, it was like the whole world stopped.

Each crew, Terra Nova's on their ship and Fram's on Antarctica moving supplies, took a second to look to their respective captains. Neither had seen them like this before—this stunned silence.

Terra Nova's crew made way for their captain, letting Adora step from the deck onto the wooden bridge.

Adora looked among her crew. The people who accompanied her, admired her, and looked up to her, even with a few bumps. She looked to Bow and Glimmer, her mates and her friends. They would have her back through this.

Adora then looked forward. Towards the Antarctic ice. Towards the future, with people behind her to push her forward.

This was to be her first step on Antarctica. Her first step to finding Mara. Her first step to the South Pole.

And her first step to seeing Catra after eight years.

Catra slowly stepped towards the docking area, watching Adora walk towards the ice, and yet keeping a fair distance. She didn't want to seem *too* eager. She didn't want to get too close.

Adora didn't look up as she walked. She wanted her first eye contact to be close and personal, to make up for that day all those years ago.

And soon, *everyone* was watching the two captains slowly begin to unite.

In the distance, Scorpia held a wooden box over her shoulder. She was on her way back to collect more supplies when she saw Terra Nova. When she saw Captain Grayskull.

And especially when she saw to her captain, her friend, her crush, her *everything*, look to someone else. Catra's back was turned on her first mate, and she was instead facing the past.

Scorpia kept her feelings pushed down. But her heart felt heavy as she watched Adora step towards the ice.

Entrapta kept her distance from the crew, checking Fram's cargo against her notes and seeing if everything matched up. She did all of this by herself, only accompanied by Emily. Asking for help was never an option.

And yet, when Emily let out a few barks, Fram's second mate looked up to see her captain awaiting the docking of another ship. It didn't take her long to piece together what was happening.

She almost wanted to go up and greet everyone on Terra Nova. See their cargo, their vehicles, their plan. She wanted to talk about so much, especially with their researchers.

And yet, she kept her distance. Alone. Isolated.

The endless contradiction kept her away.

Even on Terra Nova, Glimmer and Bow pushed their way in front of the rest of the crew, getting the best view of Adora and Catra's first meeting. They placed their hands on the ledge, watching on in silent anticipation.

But occasionally, Glimmer looked over to Bow, judging his expression. His face of study, and of hope—Hope that Adora would find her happiness.

And yet, he was nervous too. Glimmer could see that. She almost wanted to place her hand over Bow's, to comfort him.

But she kept everything to herself, standing beside him in silence.

Trapped between preservation and truth.

With over a hundred pairs of eyes on them, there was only one thing left to do between Adora and Catra. It was as if fate had brought them together to this very moment.

And now, a promise that was lost so long ago began to spark once more…

As Adora placed her feet on Antarctica for the first time.

She took a second to let out a soft gasp. Felt her heart come to a still. Let this moment sink in. That moment of a dream come to life. That moment of pure happiness.

But she hid that excitement and that joy, keeping a stern face as a captain, and chose to look up to the person who was supposed to be her rival according to the rest of the world.

For the first time in eight years, Adora and Catra came face-to-face. And out of anywhere in the world, they were finally together in the place that brought them closest, and the place that had torn them apart.

A moment of silence came between them. How much had changed in the last eight years? How much had stayed the same? Could this really even work? Should either of them speak?

Their racing minds only delayed the inevitable.

Out of the two of them, the first to take action was Adora, who finally extended a hand towards Catra. A greeting, or an act of apology, neither of them knew.

Catra looked to the hand. That first offer after so long. She had so many ways to go about this. Would accepting this hand be too much? Can she really allow herself to be vulnerable to the one who hurt her all those years ago? Or was everything that had happened her *own* fault?

There were a few seconds of hesitation. Guilt began to flood Adora's body. Fuck, maybe this was a bad idea. Adora looked to her feet, breaking eye contact. After what she did to Catra, she didn't even deserve a handshake. It was only obvious.

Adora almost drew her hand back…

But then, something warm pressed against her palm.

Adora blinked, looked up a bit, and saw Catra had taken the hand in her own, their palms clasped against one another.

Catra was holding her hand. And more than that, she was *shaking* it.

Adora sat, stunned for a few seconds, before she eventually looked up into Catra's eyes. She finally made eye contact.

"Welcome to Antarctica, captain Grayskull," spoke Fram's captain.

And softly, Catra smiled.

"I told you we'd make it."

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*End of the Promise arc.*

Chapter End Notes

> That brings us to the end of this story's first arc! The support everyone has shown so far has been so encouraging, and I really can't thank everyone enough for the lovely comments and the patience between chapters. The story's next arc will be called 'Obstacles', and although it might take a bit to get out, I'm excited to show it off!
>
> As always, comments are super appreciated and I'm always happy to respond. Thank you again!

End Notes

For updates on my fics and progress, follow me on twitter, @thepudzoutlook1. Thanks for reading!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!